

The First 90 Days After a Parent Dies

*What to Do in the United States, Hour by Hour and Week
by Week: Funerals, Death Certificates, Benefits, Bills and
Family*

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The Thermostat Was Still Set to Seventy-Two

At a quarter past noon on a Saturday in March 2016, four hours after my father died, I was standing in my parents' kitchen with a phone in my hand and nobody left to call.

I had made four calls. Dale, who was driving in from a job in Waverly. My brother in Tucson, who said he'd get the first flight he could. Our pastor. The woman who ran the church prayer chain, because Mom asked me to, and because otherwise she'd have heard it from someone else by supper.

The people whose job it is to come had come, done what they do, and gone. Mom was in the front room on the davenport with a neighbor holding her hand. The kitchen hadn't changed since 1994. Same almond refrigerator, same border of blue geese Mom hung that year and never tired of. By the wall phone sat a pharmacy notepad with Dale's work number penciled on it in Dad's square printing, though Dad knew it by heart.

By the back door was the thermostat, a round Honeywell dial with a cracked cover. It was set to seventy-two.

My father turned it up to seventy-two every morning at six, for Mom, and down to sixty-four every night at ten, for the gas bill. He had done that for as long as I could remember. He'd turned it up that morning. Tonight nobody would turn it down unless somebody decided to.

That was the first thing I understood about the next ninety days, though I couldn't have said it then. It arrives as the funeral beside the bank beside the thermostat, all in the same pile.

I wrote the time on the pharmacy pad. Under it I wrote “thermostat,” crossed it out, and wrote it again.

Dale came in the back door at ten to one. He looked at the dial, then at me.

“Leave that,” he said. “I’ll turn it down tonight.”

The shape of ninety days

I’ve done this for both of my parents. My father’s death was sudden, and nothing was ready. My mother died at home under hospice care in 2019, with most of the decisions made ahead of time, and that was hard in a different way. Between the two, I learned that the shape of these weeks is far more predictable than grief is.

The first week is loud. The phone rings, people drop by with food, the funeral home needs answers, and there’s a service to get through. You will make more decisions in those seven days than in the two months after, most of them on very little sleep.

The second week goes quiet. The family from out of town flies home. The refrigerator is full of dishes you’ll have to return. You may think the worst is over, and in one sense it is.

Then come two months of envelopes. Statements, premium notices, letters with your mother’s or father’s name showing through the little window. Each one wants something: a certified copy, a form, a signature you may or may not have the right to give. Nobody warns you about this part, because by then the people who would have warned you have gone home.

Ordered by the clock

This book follows time, not topic, because time is the one thing you can feel right now.

Chapters 1 and 2 cover the first forty-eight hours: what happens in the first hours after a death, and how to arrange a burial or cremation without being overcharged. Chapters 3, 4 and 5 are week one: certified death certificates, securing the house and everything in it, and who has to be told. Chapters 6 through 9 are weeks two to four, when the will turns up (or doesn't), the bills start, and there are benefits to check and money nobody mentioned. Chapters 10, 11 and 12 carry you through months two and three, ending on day ninety.

Every chapter opens with a line that tells you where it sits on the calendar, so you can start in the middle.

If the death was today, read the short list at the end of this introduction, then Chapter 1, and stop there. I mean stop. What you're setting aside is almost the whole book, and none of it is harmed by a night: the prices, the forms, the phone calls, the benefits, the envelopes. Every office you'd want is either shut or about to be. The only things that genuinely move in the next few hours are where your parent's body goes and whether anyone official still needs to see the room the way it is.

If it was last week, find your day in Chapters 2 through 5 and read the opening page of each chapter you skipped. You're past the part that can't be undone, and into the part where small errors cost weeks. Two things in those chapters run on a clock that doesn't wait for you to feel ready: an empty house in the wrong weather, and a count you make once and pay for twice if you get it wrong. The rest of week one is sequence, not speed. Doing the right thing on Thursday beats doing four wrong things on Monday.

If it was a month ago, start at Chapter 6. The decisions that had an audience are behind you, and what's left is paper arriving at a house nobody lives in. You've probably already done something in this book out of order, and that's fine; almost nobody gets the first three weeks tidy. Two things are worth going back for. Read Chapter 3 before you order another certified copy of anything. Read the four-

pile sort in Chapter 7 before you pay one more bill with your own money.

Each chapter has one tool in it: a checklist, a script, a counting sheet. They're meant for paper and a pen, at a kitchen table or in a parked car outside a county office.

You may be the executor. You may be the one who lives closest, which often feels like the same job and in law is nothing like it. I've written for both of you, and where the difference matters I'll point it out.

Three early mistakes

I've watched families make the same three mistakes in the first weeks, and I made one of them myself.

The first is paying bills that aren't yours to pay. A bill with your father's name on it feels like an obligation, and paying it feels like looking after him. According to the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, a person's debts are generally paid out of the money or property they left, and survivors generally aren't responsible unless they shared the debt. There are exceptions, and Chapter 7 goes through them one at a time. The default is not your checking account.

Open the envelope. Date it. Don't pay it yet.

The second is giving things away before anyone has made a list. The neighbor who always borrowed the snowblower asks if he can keep it. A grandson would love the watch. These are kind requests from kind people, and saying yes in week one is how families stop speaking to each other in month three. Chapter 4 has the rule for what stays in the house, and Chapter 11 has a fair way to divide it later.

The third is ordering death certificates by guessing. The funeral director will probably ask how many certified copies you want, and

early, before you've thought about who needs one. No government agency publishes a right number, and I'm not going to invent one. What you can do is find out which places actually require a certified copy and order to that count. Chapter 3 has the counting sheet, and the story of how I learned this the slow way.

Count, then order.

Where this book stops

This book covers the first ninety days, and it stops at the courthouse door. If you're the executor and the estate goes through probate, the court side of that job is in *The Executor's Step-by-Step Guide*. If these weeks have you looking hard at your own papers, that's *Estate Planning for Beginners*. I won't re-teach either one here. Where a subject crosses the line, you'll get a sentence and a title.

Who's talking, and when she'll send you elsewhere

I'm Ruth Calloway. I'm sixty-one. Home is Chillicothe, Ohio, a short drive from the farmhouse where my father turned that dial every morning. For twenty-seven years I did the bookkeeping for Dale's heating-and-cooling business, which is where I learned to count things before I trust them. I hold no license in law, tax, finance or medicine. What's here is what I learned doing this for my own parents, checked against official sources.

Those sources are named where they're used. Most of them are federal: the Social Security Administration, the Federal Trade Commission, the Department of Veterans Affairs, the IRS, the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, the Postal Service and Medicare.gov. One is easy to miss. The CDC's National Center for Health Statistics keeps the state-by-state index of vital records

offices, and you'll use it in Chapter 3. When I give you a figure, I'll tell you whose it is and what year it's from.

A good deal of what happens in the first two weeks is state law, and I'm in Ohio. That is a real limit on this book, and I'd rather state it plainly than paper over it.

Here is the shape of what I can't answer from here. Who may pronounce a death, and when a coroner or medical examiner has to be involved. Who gets the final say on burial or cremation when the family splits. Whether there's a waiting period before a cremation. What a certified copy of a death certificate costs, who's allowed to order one, and how many a county will issue at a time. What the DMV wants in order to cancel a licence or move a title. Whether a bank will open a safe deposit box before an estate is opened. Whether a surviving spouse owes a particular debt at all.

Those are eight different answers in fifty different places, and a book that guesses at them is worse than a book that says it doesn't know. So each time one comes up, you'll get the question to ask and the office that owns the answer: the state vital records office, the funeral director or state funeral board, the state DMV, the state insurance department, the county probate clerk. Ask them. Then write the answer down with the date and the name of the person who gave it to you, because in six weeks you won't remember which one of four people said it, and you will need to.

Get it in writing where you can.

And I'll tell you when to stop reading and call someone. A collector who says you personally owe the money. A will someone means to fight. A house owned jointly with a mortgage still on it. Grief that has stopped moving and started to look like something a doctor should hear about. In each of those places I'll name the professional, whether that's a lawyer, a CPA or a doctor, and say why, at the point where it comes up.

The next six hours

If your mother or father died today and you haven't slept, this is all you need for now. The rest of the book will keep.

1. If no nurse, doctor or emergency crew has been there yet, make that call first. If your parent was enrolled in hospice, follow the hospice agency's own after-death instructions and call its twenty-four-hour number; federal hospice rules require nursing services to be routinely available on a twenty-four-hour basis, seven days a week, so somebody will answer. If there was no hospice, call 911. The National 911 Program's standing instruction is to dial 911 immediately when you need emergency help. Either way, if the death was sudden, unexpected or involved an injury, say that out loud on the call, and move nothing until someone official tells you that you may.
2. Call one person who can come and sit with you. Not the person with the most opinions. The one who will sit.
3. Find paper and a pen. Write down the time of death as you were told it, and the name and phone number of everyone who came to the house or spoke to you at the hospital. Chapter 1 turns this into a proper log.
4. If you're asked which funeral home or crematory should take your parent, you may name one for that purpose only. Transport tonight; arrangements tomorrow, in daylight. If your faith calls for a quick burial, say so on that first call.
5. Lock the doors. Feed whatever needs feeding. Put your parent's wallet, phone, keys and medications together in one place you'll remember.
6. Leave Social Security for another day; the Social Security Administration says funeral homes generally report deaths to it,

and Chapter 5 covers what to do if yours doesn't. Leave the bank for another day too. Pay nothing.

7. Sign no contracts tonight, and promise nobody anything in the house.

Then lie down, even if you can't sleep. Somebody else can turn the thermostat down.

Chapter 1: The First Few Hours

The squad was already in the driveway when I got there, a little after half past eight on that Saturday morning in March, backed in over the gravel with the diesel still running and the light bar turning against the side of the barn.

Mom had called them and then called me. Twenty minutes from my house to theirs, and I don't remember any of the drive.

The storm door was propped open with somebody's boot. They'd pulled a kitchen chair out into the hallway, the way you do when there isn't room. A young medic came out to meet me on the step, and he was kind about it, and then he said the thing that I have thought about every year since.

"Do you have a funeral home?"

I said I didn't know. He nodded and waited, because waiting was all he could do. He wasn't allowed to pick one for me. He wasn't allowed to tell me what happened next, either, because what happened next depended on things neither of us had said out loud yet.

That is the first hour. Everyone in the room has a job, every job is narrow, and the space between those jobs is yours.

Which of the three mornings you're in

There are really only three versions of this, and almost everything about the next few hours follows from which one you got.

The first is an expected death at home, with hospice already involved. If your mother or father was enrolled in hospice, your first

call is to that agency's twenty-four-hour number, and you follow the instructions they gave you when they set up the plan of care. Those instructions are not generic. They were written for your parent, by the team Medicare says you and your family work with to set that plan up, and they usually tell you exactly what to do with medications, who the attending doctor is, and whether a nurse is coming out. Under the federal hospice rules at 42 CFR 418.100, nursing, physician and drug services have to be routinely available twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week. So call that number at two in the morning, and follow the instructions the agency gave you, even if the voice on the other end belongs to someone you've never spoken to.

If you can't reach hospice, or you aren't certain your parent has died, or you think anyone in that house is in danger, call 911 and do what the dispatcher tells you. A squad arriving at a hospice death is not a disaster.

The second version is a death in a hospital or a nursing facility. Here the staff own the first hour and they have done it before. Somebody will come and tell you, somebody else will come and ask you questions, and the two of them may not be in touch with each other. Your job is to slow it down by about ten percent and find out who's running it. The question is: who is handling this from here, and what do you need from me today.

The third version is mine. Sudden, unattended, at home, with no hospice and no plan. Here you call 911, and you say what you found, in plain words, as early in the call as you can manage. That is what the federal National 911 Program tells people to do, and the dispatcher takes it from there.

If you are not certain the person has died, that is not a question for a book. Call and do exactly what the dispatcher tells you, including starting chest compressions if they tell you to, and let them call it off. Nobody has ever been sorry for that.

Say the hard words on the first call

Whichever version you're in, there are facts that change what the people coming will do, and you want them said in the first thirty seconds rather than discovered in the hallway.

That the death was sudden, or unexpected, or came after a fall or an injury. That there was alcohol or a new medication involved. That nobody had seen your parent since Thursday. That there's a do-not-resuscitate order or a POLST form on the refrigerator, in which case go get it and have it in your hand before they come through the door. Whether that document should exist in the first place, and how a family puts one in place, is *Estate Planning for Beginners*, and I'm not going to use your morning on it.

And then the hard part, which is to stop tidying.

If the death was sudden, move nothing. Not the glass. Not the pill bottles. Not the blanket that is half off. It feels wrong, because your whole body wants to make your mother or father look cared-for before strangers walk in, and I understand that completely. Do it anyway. The people who arrive may need the room as it is, and once you've moved something you can't unmove it.

Move nothing yet.

Who pronounces, and why I can't tell you

Somebody has to formally determine that the death has occurred and put a time on it. Who is allowed to do that is state law, and it also depends on which of the three mornings you're in. In one state a hospice nurse may pronounce. In another it's a physician, or the coroner's office, or a specific procedure over the telephone. I'm in Ohio, you may not be, and a book that guesses at this is worse than a book that admits the limit.

So don't guess, and don't let a relative guess for you. Ask the people standing in front of you. The hospice nurse knows. The

facility's charge nurse knows. The 911 dispatcher and the crew in your driveway know. Ask it flatly:

"Who is pronouncing, and what time are they putting down?"

Then write the answer on whatever paper is nearest, and write whose mouth it came out of. That time of death is going to be asked of you by six different organizations over the next three months, and every one of them will act as if you obviously know it.

The question that tells you how the day will go

There's a second question, and it's the one that actually decides your afternoon.

"Is this being released to a funeral home, or is it going to the medical examiner first?"

If the medical examiner or coroner takes jurisdiction, ask where your parent is being taken, whether the office expects to release them to the funeral home, and who will update you. Local law and the facts of the death control the timing. In some cases there's an examination, and you'll be told about it rather than asked. This, too, is state law, and the circumstances that trigger it differ from one state line to the next, so ask the question instead of assuming.

It is not a judgment on your family. I've watched people hear the word "coroner" and go grey, convinced that somebody thinks they did something. Usually it means the death was sudden, or unattended, or doesn't yet have a doctor willing to certify a cause. It is paperwork wearing a frightening coat.

What it does mean is that you should not promise anyone a date. Not a service, not a viewing, not a flight home for a cousin. Say "I'll know more tomorrow," and mean it.

If you are ever in the small minority of cases where the questions turn from what happened to what you did, stop talking and call a

lawyer. That is a rare morning, and it is not one to improvise through.

What a pronouncement gives you, and what it doesn't

Here's where a lot of families lose a week, and it's such a small misunderstanding.

The pronouncement produces a time of death, and that time goes onto a record that other people fill in and sign. It is not a death certificate. Nobody is going to hand you a document at the house. The medic will not have one in the truck. The nurse will not print one.

The certified death certificate comes later, from your state or county vital records office, and the funeral director usually gets the first batch for you. How many you'll need and how to count them is Chapter 3, and that chapter exists because I got it wrong.

For now, understand only this: for the next several days you may have nothing on paper proving your parent died. You will still be expected to function. That is normal, and it is not a sign that you've missed a step.

The only decision you actually have to make today

You'll be asked where your parent should go. That's it. That is the single decision the first hours genuinely require, and it is smaller than it feels, because it does not have to be the final one.

What you're arranging is transport. A vehicle and two people. You are not buying a funeral at nine in the morning in your mother's hallway, and anyone who tries to sell you one there has told you something useful about themselves.

Say it in these words, or something close:

“I’m not making arrangements today. I’m asking you to transport, and we’ll come in tomorrow to talk about the rest.”

Then ask two questions and write down the answers. What do you charge for the transfer. And if we decide to use a different funeral home, what happens to that charge. The Federal Trade Commission’s Funeral Rule says a funeral director has to give you price information on the telephone when you ask for it, and you don’t have to give your name first. The written documents come at set points later: a General Price List that’s yours to keep when you visit to make arrangements, and an itemized statement of what you’ve chosen after you select and before you pay. Chapter 2 walks through all of it. Have that conversation in daylight, with someone else in the room.

Two exceptions to “tomorrow.” If your faith requires burial within a day, say that on the very first call, to the funeral home and to the hospital or facility at the same time, so nobody is working to the wrong clock. And if your parent had already chosen and paid a funeral home, that’s the one to call, and the folder with the paperwork is probably where they kept the tax returns.

If you have no idea which funeral home, pick the one that will answer the phone and say the sentence above. Transport is reversible. Most of the rest of this book is about things that aren’t.

If someone raises donation

At a hospital, and sometimes at home, a member of staff may ask about organ, eye or tissue donation, and the timing of that question can feel brutal. It’s asked early because the medical window is short, not because anyone is rushing you emotionally.

Two things are worth knowing while you decide. The hospital and the organ procurement organization run the process, not you; you

can find your local one through organdonor.gov, which the federal Health Resources and Services Administration operates. And if you think your parent signed up as a donor, don't argue it from memory.

Ask the organ procurement organization three things. Whether a registration is on record. What legal effect it has in your state. And whether the family is being asked to decide, or only to supply information. Organdonor.gov tells people who sign up to share that decision with family, precisely so the family may be spared from having to make it, so a registration may already have answered the question you think is yours.

Donation is possible only in particular medical circumstances, so if nobody raises it, nothing has gone wrong. If nobody raises it and you have a question, ask the hospital team or the organ procurement organization what decision, if any, the family needs to make.

Have one person in the family speak to the organization, and write the answer down. Then let it go. Families do better when one relative holds that conversation than when five of them relitigate it at midnight.

Three calls, not thirty

Here is the mistake I watch people make at eleven in the morning, with the house still full of strangers: they start calling everybody.

It's understandable. Saying it out loud is how you start to believe it. But every call you make generates four more, and by two in the afternoon you are hosting a switchboard instead of sitting down.

Call the people who would be genuinely hurt to hear it secondhand, and who need to make travel decisions today. That is usually three or four names. Then hand the phone to somebody else. Pick one person, tell them they are the phone, and let them take the rest. They'll be glad of a job; most people who turn up want one and don't know how to ask.

There's one more category that isn't about feelings at all. Anyone whose own arrangements collapse because of this death: the aide who was coming at two, the other parent's day program, the kennel, the neighbor who was expecting your father to drive them to dialysis on Monday. Those calls are short and they are not optional.

Everyone else keeps until tomorrow, and the banks and the government offices keep until next week.

The tool: the phone log

Start this today, on paper, before you think you need it. Mine lives on a legal pad because a legal pad doesn't need charging and doesn't lock itself.

Rule one line across the top of the page and make five columns.

1. **Date and time.** The actual time, not "morning."
2. **Who you called, or who called you.** The organization, and the number you reached them on.
3. **Who you actually spoke to.** First name at minimum. Ask for a last initial and a direct extension, and ask them to repeat it.
4. **What they said.** One line. The answer, not the chat.
5. **What they need from you, and by when.** The thing you must send, sign or bring, and the date it's due.

Then add a reference number anywhere one is offered, and date-stamp it.

The rule that makes the log work is a hard one: an unlogged call did not happen. If it isn't on the pad, you did not make it, and you will make it again in three weeks with a different person who has no record of the first one.

Why bother, on a day like today? Because the first hours produce the facts that every later month depends on, and they're handed to

you by people whose names you will not retain. The medic. The nurse. The person from the facility who said they'd take care of something.

I know, because I didn't write any of it down. Three weeks later I had the time of my father's death in two places, and the two didn't match, and I spent most of a Tuesday afternoon on the telephone finding out which one was right. It was the smallest possible problem and it still ate an afternoon I didn't have.

Start the log in the first hour. It is the cheapest thing in this book.

Before you lie down

By early afternoon the house will empty out. The squad goes, the nurse goes, the neighbors go home to make something in a dish.

When Dale finally got there that Saturday, he didn't ask me any questions. He walked the house once, checked the back door, and sat down.

"Did you eat?"

I hadn't. That turned out to be the thing I most needed someone to notice.

So: the log on the table, the pen on top of it, and the small things gathered into the one spot you named last night. Then stop. Tomorrow is the money day, and you will want to have slept before it.

Chapter 2: Buying a Funeral While You Can Barely Stand Up

Kevin's flight got in at ten-forty that night, and by eleven he was standing in the kitchen with his coat still on, talking about cremation like it was a line item.

"It's simpler. It's cheaper. Dad wouldn't have wanted a fuss." He wasn't wrong about any of those things, necessarily. He was also exhausted, three time zones off his own clock, and trying to solve a feeling by solving a decision.

I had the phone number for the first funeral home already written on the pad from Chapter 1, under the medic's question. I told Kevin we weren't deciding tonight. He said we didn't have forever. I said we had until tomorrow afternoon, and that was true, and it bought us both enough sleep to have the actual conversation like people who loved the same man.

You are shopping while tired, shocked, and short on time

That changes what a price conversation feels like.

Here is the condition the next few days put you in: no time, nothing to compare it to, and no appetite for the conversation at all. You will likely make the biggest discretionary purchase of your year inside a room designed to be calm, quiet, and slightly dim.

That is not an accusation against funeral directors. Most of the ones I've dealt with were decent people doing a hard job well. But the condition is real, and a set of federal rules exists because of it.

The Funeral Rule, in plain words

The FTC Funeral Rule, enforced by the Federal Trade Commission, exists to let you buy only what you want and pay only for that. You are allowed to pick goods and services separately instead of accepting a package built around items you didn't ask for.

It has real limits, and knowing them keeps you from being surprised later. It doesn't apply to third-party sellers — a separate casket or monument dealer you find online or across town. And it doesn't apply to a cemetery that has no funeral home on its own site. If you end up buying a vault or a headstone from one of those, you're dealing with ordinary consumer protections, not this specific rule.

What you can actually ask for

According to the FTC's page on the Funeral Rule, you have the right to:

Price information on the telephone, before you give your name. Ask, and the funeral home has to tell you.

A written, itemized General Price List to keep when an in-person discussion of prices, service type, or specific goods and services begins — wherever that discussion happens, including at your kitchen table or the hospital. It lists everything the home offers and what each thing costs, and it's yours to keep, not a document you hand back.

A casket price list, in writing, before anyone walks you past the actual caskets.

An outer burial container price list, same rule, before you're shown the containers.

A written statement, after you've chosen and before you pay, showing exactly what you selected and what each item costs.

A written explanation of any cemetery or crematory requirement that forces you to buy a specific good or service.

An alternative container instead of a casket, if you're choosing cremation. No state or local law anywhere requires a casket for cremation.

The right to supply your own casket or urn, bought elsewhere. The funeral home cannot refuse to use it, cannot charge you a fee for handling it, and cannot require you to be there when it's delivered.

Arrangements without embalming. There's a chapter's worth of mythology built on this one, so it gets its own section below.

That's a longer list than most people expect, and almost nobody reads it before they need it. Put the list beside the phone before you call the second home.

Three things people are told that aren't true

“Embalming is required.” It isn't, as a blanket rule. No state law requires routine embalming for every death, according to the FTC. Some states require embalming or refrigeration if the body won't be buried or cremated within a certain window; some require neither. Refrigeration is usually an acceptable alternative. If a viewing matters to your family, ask whether a private viewing is possible without embalming, and ask what refrigeration costs instead.

“The cemetery requires a vault or liner by law.” State laws do not require a burial vault or liner anywhere, and a funeral provider may not tell you otherwise. What's true is narrower and still worth knowing: many cemeteries, as a matter of their own policy, require some kind of outer container so the ground doesn't eventually sink. That's the cemetery's rule, not the state's, and it has to be disclosed to you in writing and priced before you're shown any containers.

“This casket will preserve her.” The Funeral Rule prohibits that claim outright, for any casket, at any price. No casket preserves

a body indefinitely, metal or wood, gasketed or not, and a seller isn't allowed to say otherwise.

I mention these three because they're the ones I heard myself, in one form or another, in the two days after Gene died. None of it was said to cheat us. It was said because it's what the person saying it had always said. Ask the direct question anyway: "Is that required by law, or is that your policy?"

Reading the bill before you sign it

The bill you'll be handed has three kinds of lines on it, and they behave differently.

The **basic services fee** is the one you can't decline. It covers the things common to every funeral regardless of what else you choose: funeral planning, securing the necessary permits, arranging for copies of the death certificate, preparing notices, sheltering the remains, and coordinating with the cemetery or crematory. You're going to see this fee on every quote from every home, and you can't shop it down to zero. You can compare it between homes.

Everything after that is **separately priced**, and this is where your choices actually live: transporting the remains, embalming or other preparation, use of the building for a viewing or service, a hearse, the casket or container itself, cremation or interment. Decline anything you don't want. Nobody can bundle it back in.

Cash advance items are things the funeral home buys on your behalf from someone else: flowers, an obituary notice, clergy, musicians. Some homes charge you their own cost for these. Some add a markup on top. The Funeral Rule requires them to disclose in writing if they mark it up, though not the exact amount. It also requires them to tell you about any refund or rebate the outside vendor offers. If a cash advance line looks padded, ask directly whether there's a markup on it.

What this book will not tell you a funeral costs

I'm not going to give you a number for "what a funeral costs," and if another book hands you one, ask where it came from. There is no current-year government source that publishes an average price, and the industry figures that do exist aren't federal data. The FTC's July 2012 shopping guidance recommends comparing at least two funeral homes; its own cost figures from that page are old enough that I wouldn't treat them as today's prices, but the comparison advice holds. You already have the right to ask for prices without giving your name. Use it twice before you use it zero times.

The itemized statement is your proof

After you've chosen what you want and before you hand over a card, the funeral home has to give you a written statement showing exactly what you selected and the cost of each item. The FTC requires this timing specifically: after selection, before payment, not folded into a contract you sign on the way in the door.

There's no required format for this statement. It might be a single page, it might be several, and it will look different from one home to the next. What matters is that every line on it should match something you actually agreed to out loud. If a line appears that nobody discussed, ask about it before you sign, not after. If a cash advance item's exact cost isn't known yet, the home is required to give you a written good-faith estimate instead of leaving it blank.

Keep this statement with the phone log from Chapter 1. You'll want it again when a bank or an insurer asks what the funeral actually cost, and you will not want to be hunting for it in a drawer in June.

Buying yourself twenty-four hours

Back to Kevin, at eleven at night, wanting it settled by breakfast.

What actually worked wasn't an argument. It was a sentence, and then silence: "We are not deciding tonight. We're deciding tomorrow afternoon, after we've both slept and after I've called two places." He didn't love it. He didn't fight it either, because it wasn't a no. It was a when.

If your sibling is the one pushing for speed, you don't have to explain hospice rules or grief psychology to slow things down. You need a specific later time, said once, calmly. Then you need to actually call back at that time. The fastest way to lose the delay is to let it drift into three days by accident.

There's one real exception to taking your time, worth naming so nobody mistakes caution for delay. If your family's faith requires burial within a day, say so on the very first call, to every party involved, so nobody is quietly working to the wrong clock.

When the family disagrees about who decides

Kevin wanted cremation. I wasn't sure. Dale had no opinion and wisely stayed out of it. In a different family, that disagreement goes further, and here's the part I can't resolve for you from this page: who has the final legal say over burial or cremation when relatives disagree is set by state law. The order of priority among surviving relatives differs from state to state.

Ask the funeral director directly what your state's order of priority is, and ask for it in writing rather than taking it as a verbal aside. It is not a question that embarrasses anyone to ask.

If the answer is disputed, or the director says someone else has authority to authorize the disposition, pause and call a local estate lawyer before anyone signs. Who can authorize this is state law, and

a rushed mistake can be hard to undo. A funeral director is not your lawyer, and the signature on an authorization form is not a draft.

The one sentence about power of attorney, and nowhere else

If your parent had given someone power of attorney to handle money, sign papers or make decisions, that authority ended the moment they died. A power of attorney dies with the person. Whoever held it yesterday holds nothing today, for funeral arrangements or anything else, and anyone telling you otherwise is mistaken. Setting up your own power of attorney, for your own future, belongs to *Estate Planning for Beginners*, and this is the only place in this book I'll mention it.

The tool: the telephone price call

Call two funeral homes before you walk into either one. Lead with the questions, not your name. Ask every item below in a flat, unhurried voice, no matter how rushed the person sounds on their end. Write the answer next to each question, and compare the two sheets side by side before you decide anything.

1. What is your basic services fee, and what does it include?
2. What is your direct-cremation price, what container and services does it include, and what charges could still be added?
3. For a burial with your least-expensive casket, what charges are from your home, what does that include, and which cemetery or third-party charges are excluded?
4. Do you charge a fee to use a casket or urn purchased elsewhere?
5. Is embalming required for what I'm asking for, or is it your policy?

6. What do you charge for transport only, if I decide on arrangements tomorrow?
7. Do you mark up cash advance items like flowers or the obituary, and by roughly how much?
8. How many certified death certificates does your basic fee cover securing, and what does an additional one cost through you?
9. What is my state's order of priority if family members disagree about burial or cremation?

Keep both sheets. You'll want them again at the actual appointment, not just before it.

Tomorrow we count certified death certificates properly, which is a smaller problem than tonight's and one I solved the hard way.

Chapter 3: Certified Copies, and How to Count Them

Monday morning, the day after we'd signed the paperwork with the funeral home, I called the pension office with a photocopy of Dad's death certificate in my hand, feeling official about it. The woman on the other end was polite. She also explained, in the tone of someone who has said this sentence a thousand times, that a photocopy wasn't going to do anything for either of us. She needed a certified copy issued by the relevant vital records office, not the photocopy in my hand. The issuing office's certification may be printed, embossed, signed, sealed or otherwise secured; don't reject or demand a copy based on appearance alone. Not a scan. Not a fax. Not the stapled packet the funeral home had handed me in a manila folder.

I hadn't known there was a difference. That's the whole chapter, really, except for the part where I learned it twice.

What a certified copy actually is

A certified copy is a record issued by a government vital records office that the office itself certifies as a true copy of the record on file. A photocopy of one, a scan of one, a PDF you emailed yourself — none of those count, because only the issuing office can create the certified copy. Illinois, for one, draws the line this way on its official death-records page: certified copies are the ones suitable for legal purposes, and uncertified informational copies are not. That's the entire reason banks and insurers reject photocopies at the counter.

This matters because there's no master original you photocopy for free once you have it. A certified copy may carry a fee and take time to obtain. Check the issuing office named by the CDC index for its current fee, any fee waivers, the ordering methods it accepts, and its processing estimate.

Where they come from, and it isn't Washington

Here's a thing almost nobody gets right on the first try: the federal government does not issue death certificates. There is no national office, no federal form, no 1-800 number in Washington that will mail you one. Death certificates come from the issuing jurisdiction's vital records office, not a federal certificate office, and that office keeps its own hours, its own fees, and its own rules about who may order a copy.

What the federal government does maintain is a directory, not a certificate office. The federal health-statistics index I mentioned in the introduction, "Where to Write for Vital Records," names each jurisdiction's vital records office, how to reach it, and what it requires to process an application. Note that it lists more than states — territories, and in some cases a city registrar separate from the state one, as with New York State and New York City. Chapter 00 pointed you toward this listing in passing; here is where you actually use it. The listing is the map. It is not the certificate. If you remember one sentence from this chapter, make it this one: find the place your parent died on that listing, then deal directly with the issuing office it names.

That listing also means the rules genuinely differ depending on where your parent died, not where you live. Who may legally order a copy is one question. How much a copy costs is another. How many copies the issuing office will issue in one sitting is a third. New York's own vital records page makes the point plainly: eligibility and fees

there depend on who is applying and how they order. None of those three questions has one national answer. Ask every one of them out loud, write the answer down, and don't assume Ohio's answer is your state's answer.

A fourth question belongs in that same phone call and most people forget it: how long the office expects processing to take if you order by mail instead of walking in. Mail processing can differ sharply — as retrieved in 2026, Ohio's health department posted five business days to process an online order with delivery expected in about three weeks, while Illinois posted roughly twelve weeks for mailed requests. Read the current estimate on the issuing office's own page before deciding whether to order by mail, online or in person.

Why you probably already have a few

As Chapter 2 noted, a funeral provider may arrange the first copies. Under the FTC's Funeral Rule, obtaining copies of death certificates sits among the basic services a funeral director performs — but the Rule also treats death certificates as items a provider may pass through as a cash advance. So the provider's work to obtain copies may be part of basic services, while the certificate charges themselves may appear separately. Check the General Price List and the itemized statement before you assume anything is already paid for.

In practice, this means many families get their first batch of certified copies through the funeral director, who files the paperwork with the issuing office on your behalf. That's genuinely useful, and it's also exactly where people like me get into trouble, because the funeral home will ask you, often within the first day or two, how many copies you want. And at that point you have no idea. Neither did I.

The question nobody asks you to answer with a number

Here is what I want to save you from doing, because it's what I did: guessing a round number and ordering that many. Five sounded responsible. Five was wrong, and not in the direction you'd think.

There is no agency, state or federal, that publishes a correct number of certified copies for settling an estate. Anyone who tells you a specific number — “get twelve,” “get twenty, you'll need them” — is guessing, the same as I was. The honest approach is slower and less satisfying, but it actually works: you count the institutions, one at a time, before you order anything.

Here's how that conversation goes. You call the bank, the brokerage, the insurer, whoever's on your list, and you ask. First: do you require a certified copy of the death certificate, or will something else do? Second, if yes: do you return the certified copy once you've recorded what you need from it, or do you keep it? Third, and this is the one I'd have skipped: what format do you accept, must the copy have been issued within a certain period, and may I reuse a returned paper copy with you? Some places accept a certified electronic record and never touch paper. Some want one issued within the last few months. You will not know which kind of institution you're dealing with until you ask, because it varies by company, not by industry, and sometimes even by branch.

Then count from what they actually told you, in writing where you can get it, rather than from any assumption of mine. If an institution says in so many words that it records the copy and returns it, and that a reused copy is fine, that copy can go to the next name on your list. If it keeps the copy, or insists on a recently issued one, that's a copy you have to supply. Add a small personal margin on top of that count if you want one for your own files or for a sibling's, but that margin is a choice, not a requirement from anyone official.

Write every answer down in the phone log from Chapter 1. When the bank says “we photocopy it and give it back,” that line goes in the log with a date, because three weeks from now you will not remember which of eleven institutions said what.

Cause of death, and the one place it matters

Some jurisdictions offer more than one death-record product, or restrict the medical information on certain versions. Ask the issuing office which versions exist where your parent died, and ask the recipient which one it requires. One recipient worth asking early is the VA, if you’re filing for burial benefits. Chapter 8 covers that claim in full; the short version here is that VA says you may need a death certificate that includes the cause of death for burial and transportation benefits. If your parent was a veteran, raise that when you order, rather than discovering the gap while you’re already filling out the form.

Beyond that one case, ask each institution which version it wants before you order a stack of the wrong kind. It’s a sentence added to the same phone call you were already making. Nobody minds the extra question. The clerk at the county office has heard it a hundred times, and the person at the bank would rather tell you now than reject your mailed-in packet three weeks from now and make you start over.

Sometimes an out-of-state office or an older relative insists the certification should look a particular way. Don’t argue it from the sofa. Ask the issuing office what forms of certification it produces, ask the recipient what it accepts, and let those two answers settle it. It’s one more line on calls you’re making anyway.

What it cost us, in driving, not dollars

The second time I drove to the county health department, it was raining, the kind of flat gray April rain that doesn't let up long enough to make running from the car worth it. I'd ordered five certified copies the first week, confident that was plenty, because five had felt like a generous number compared to the one I actually needed that first day.

It wasn't enough. The brokerage kept its copy. The life insurer kept its copy. The title company handling the house kept its copy. By the third week I was down to one, with two institutions still on the list, and a fourth that called back to say the copy I'd sent hadn't scanned clearly and they needed a fresh one.

So I drove back. I stood in the same line, filled out the same form, paid the same fee again, and drove home with two more certified copies that I'd have already had if I'd asked the "does it get returned" question before I ordered the first batch. The actual cost wasn't large. The cost was an afternoon in April rain that I didn't have to spend, on top of a month that had already taken most of my afternoons.

If you take one practical thing from this chapter, let it be this: count before you order, not after you run out.

What to do with them once you have them

Certified copies are small, official, and easy to lose track of in a house that's already full of paper. One labeled envelope, kept beside the phone log and the funeral home's itemized statement from Chapter 2. One list taped to the inside flap, every certified copy numbered, with a line for who has it and the date it left the envelope. When a copy comes back from an institution that returns it, it goes back in the envelope and gets crossed off the "out" column, not thrown loose in a drawer.

This sounds like overkill for a handful of pieces of paper. It isn't. The list tells you where each copy is when the next institution asks for one.

The short, flat warning you'll want to ignore

Ordering more later means going back to the issuing office, likely another fee, and another wait while nothing else on your list moves forward. It is not a catastrophe. It is also not free, in time or in patience, and both of those are already in short supply this month. Count first. Order once if you can. Order again without guilt if you can't — just don't guess twice.

The tool: the certificate count

Make one line for every bank, brokerage, insurer, pension office, employer, title company, land registry and benefits office on your notification list. For each one, write:

Does this institution require a certified copy, or will another form of proof work? Does it return the copy once it's recorded what it needs, or keep it? Paper or electronic? Any limit on how old the copy may be? Will it take one that another institution already handled? Which version does it want, if the issuing office offers more than one?

Total the copies you'll have to supply because the institution said it keeps them or won't take a reused one. Everything the institution told you it returns and will accept secondhand can travel down your list. Add a small personal margin at the end if you want copies for your own records or for a sibling, and write that number in separately so you can see at a glance what was necessity and what was choice.

Keep this sheet in the same envelope as the certificates themselves. Tomorrow the work moves to the house — the locks, the mail, the dog nobody's fed yet — and you won't want to be hunting for a counting sheet in a different pile.

Chapter 4: The House, the Car, the Dog and the Mail

Marlene came across the road last spring with a coffee cake and one question. How long can a house sit empty, she wanted to know, before something happens to it?

The honest answer is less comforting than a number. Cold weather can turn one unattended night into damage, but an empty house needs attention this week in any season. Leaks, heat, animals and the simple fact that nobody is looking don't wait for February.

You're somewhere in the first week now, and the house is the part of this that will not wait for you to feel ready. Paperwork sits still. A furnace doesn't.

I learned that in the wrong order. When Dad died the farmhouse wasn't empty, because Mom was still in it, and I spent that week worrying about banks instead of pipes. Three years later, after Mom died, I stood in that same kitchen on the fifth day with my coat on, looking at a thermostat somebody had turned down to fifty in a hurry, and I understood that this was now a building nobody lived in. That's a different thing to own. A building nobody lives in has no one to notice the smell of gas, the drip under the sink, the back door that didn't catch.

Dale said one sentence about it, which is his habit. "Set it to fifty-five and leave it. Cheaper than a plumber."

Heat, water, and the two numbers you write on the pad

Walk in and deal with the mechanical house before you touch a single piece of paper.

Find the thermostat and set it somewhere that will keep the pipes from freezing in your climate, then write the number you set it to on the phone log from Chapter 1, with the date. You are going to be asked by a sibling, an insurance agent and possibly a real estate agent what the house is sitting at, and you will not remember.

Find the main water shutoff and know where it is even if you don't close it. Whether you shut the water off depends on whether anything in that house needs it. A furnace with a humidifier, a sump pump, a basement with any history of water at all — those change the answer. If the house has a sump pump, the power stays on, and that is not negotiable.

Find the panel. Find the gas meter. If you smell gas, leave and call the utility from outside, and don't go back in to check the stove.

Write both numbers down. Thermostat and water.

Call the insurer before you call anyone else

Here's the one I'd put at the top of the week if I could only save you from a single mistake in this chapter.

Call whoever insures that house and tell them, in plain words, that the policyholder has died and nobody is living there. Then ask three things and write the answers down: what does the policy require of you now, what does it stop covering once the house is unoccupied, and what do you have to do to keep it in force. Ask for the answer in writing or in an email you can keep.

I'm not going to tell you what your policy says, because I haven't read it and policies differ. What I will tell you is that an empty house and a lived-in house are not the same risk to the company carrying it.

The time to find out how yours treats the difference is this week, while the premium is paid and the coverage is intact. Not in six weeks, with water in the basement and a claim to argue about.

Ask for it in writing.

While you have them on the phone: ask what happens to the policy itself. There's a dead person's name on it, and someone has to tell you whose job it is to keep paying it and from what account. You may not like the answer. Get it anyway.

Count the keys

I thought I knew who had a key to my parents' house. I counted four. By that Friday I knew about seven.

There was one in a magnetic box under the back step, which I'd known about since I was fourteen and had forgotten entirely. There was one with the man who rented the hay ground behind the house, who had held it for eleven years in case a pipe let go while they were in Florida. There was one with the woman who had cleaned every other Friday, who called me about it herself, which was decent of her. There was a lockbox hanging on the rail by the back door from the equipment deliveries, and the code was written on a piece of masking tape inside the cupboard, which rather defeats a lockbox.

So the exercise is this: write down every person who might have a key, and then call them. Not to accuse anybody. Just to know. Neighbors, cleaners, aides, grandchildren, the church friend who watered plants, the lawn service, the person who fed the cat the last time anybody went anywhere.

Then decide whether to change the locks, knowing the real number instead of the number you assumed. Sometimes the answer is no — a trusted neighbor with a key is worth more than a new deadbolt, especially if you live an hour away. Sometimes the answer is obviously yes. The point isn't which you choose. The point is that

you choose it on purpose, with a list in front of you, rather than finding out in March that seven people could walk in.

Nothing leaves the house

Now the uncomfortable part, and I'm going to be flat about it because softening it has never helped anybody.

Nothing leaves that house. Not the rifle in the hall closet. Not the ring your mother told you in 2011 was yours. Not the tools your brother has been borrowing for a decade. Not the casserole dish that belongs to the neighbor, honestly, until somebody has written down that it belongs to the neighbor.

This is not about mistrust, although sometimes it is. It's that a house full of a dead person's belongings is the single easiest thing in the next ninety days to make unfixable. Once an object is gone, there is no list you can make that puts it back, and there is no conversation about who should have had it that doesn't start with an accusation. A fair way to divide what's in that house is Chapter 11's job, and it is a real job that deserves its own chapter. Week one is not the time, and a hallway is not the place.

What you do instead costs nothing: you take photographs. Every room, every drawer you open anyway, every surface. Your phone date-stamps them for you. If a cousin arrives on Saturday and leaves with a clock, you'll know, and knowing is most of the battle.

If there are firearms in the house, secure them in place against unauthorized access, and leave them there. Who may take possession of a dead person's gun, and how it may be transferred, is governed by both federal and state law, and I am not qualified to tell you how either applies to you. So before any firearm changes hands, ask a local estate lawyer and a federally licensed dealer what estate authority and what federal and state law require. And don't let a

well-meaning relative drive off with a shotgun in the truck bed because it seemed tidier.

Medications are the other thing to deal with on sight. Get them out of the open, especially anything controlled. If your parent was on hospice, the instructions that agency gave you covered this — go look at them again. If not, ask the pharmacy that filled them what to do with what's left, rather than flushing it or handing it to a relative who takes the same drug.

The car, and the one place I'd leave well alone

Do not cancel the auto policy. Notify the insurer of the death now and ask, in writing, what must change to keep the parked vehicle covered and who may drive it. A dead person's name on a policy raises the same questions the house policy raised, and the answers come from the insurer, not from me. Cancelling instead is the sort of thing that feels responsible at the time and costs money later. Get the car off the street and into the garage or the driveway if you can.

Then leave the title alone.

Transferring a vehicle title out of a dead person's name, and cancelling a driver's license, are state procedures run by your state's motor vehicle agency. They differ enough that I'd be doing you harm by describing Ohio's and letting you assume it's yours. Look up your own state's motor vehicle website, find its page for a deceased owner, and read what it actually requires. Some states have a short-form process for a surviving spouse. Some want court paperwork first. You cannot know which yours is without looking, and the cost of guessing is a wasted morning in a license bureau with a numbered ticket in your hand.

Write the plate number, the VIN and the insurer's phone number on the pad while you're standing there looking at the car. Then close the garage.

The dog nobody has thought about

Somewhere around day two there's an animal in this story, and because nobody put it on a list, it becomes an emergency at nine o'clock at night.

Here's the whole plan, and it's short. Call the animal's own veterinarian, because they have the records, they know what it's on, and they will often board it or know who does. Look for anything your parent wrote down about the animal, because people who worry about their pets frequently did write something, and it's usually in the same drawer as the pet's paperwork. Name one family member who has the animal, by name, out loud, so that three people don't each assume somebody else is feeding it. If no family member can take it, call the local humane society or animal shelter and ask what they can do — not as a last resort you should feel bad about, as a phone call.

Then write down who has the animal and who is paying for its food and its vet. That last part prevents a specific small resentment that otherwise grows all summer.

The mail is where the next three months are hiding

Half of what you will need to know in the next ninety days is going to arrive at that mailbox, addressed to a dead person, from companies you have never heard of. Which also means that mailbox is now the least secure thing on the property, and it's standing at the end of the driveway.

Start with what you're actually allowed to do, because this is the place where well-meaning families get themselves into trouble.

The Postal Service draws the line at whether you shared the address. If you lived with the person who died and you keep getting their mail, USPS says on its page about mail addressed to the

deceased that you may open and manage it as needed. You may also forward all of it. And you may forward a single piece, to an appointed executor say, without going anywhere: neatly cross out your address, print “Forward to” and the new address on the front, and leave it for your carrier or drop it in a collection box.

If you did not share the address, the rule is stricter than almost anyone expects. To have a dead person’s mail forwarded to a different address, USPS says you have to go in person to a Post Office location with documented proof that you are the appointed executor or administrator authorized to manage that mail. The page says plainly that simply having their death certificate is not enough. I checked it again in 2026 and it still reads that way.

Read that twice, because it reorders your week. Appointment comes from a court, and the court side of becoming an appointed representative is *The Executor’s Step-by-Step Guide*, not this book. What matters here is what you do in the meantime, which is not nothing:

If you shared the address, follow USPS’s shared-address options above. If you did not, a house or mailbox key does not prove authority to manage the mail. Before appointment, call the local Post Office, explain the death, and ask what it permits while the estate waits for papers; contact urgent senders directly. Do not remove, open, redirect, hold, or ask a neighbor to collect the mail unless USPS or a lawyer confirms that you may.

And do not tell the Post Office, or a bank, or anybody else that you are the executor if no court has said so. That sentence is the one that turns a grieving daughter into a person who made a false statement, and it is entirely avoidable.

When somebody does have the appointment papers and files that change of address, know what you’re buying. For a permanent change of address, USPS generally forwards First-Class Mail for twelve months, but periodicals for sixty days; USPS Marketing Mail

generally is not forwarded. Mark day sixty on the calendar, because the statements and notices that arrive as periodicals stop coming to you long before the rest of it does.

Separately, USPS's forwarding page, as it read in 2026, says standard forwarding can be extended for six, twelve or eighteen more months, with eighteen the maximum and the extension non-refundable. Check that page for which classes an extension covers. They are not the same as the standard list. Forwarding may begin within three business days, but the page tells you to allow up to two weeks. When the forwarding period ends, USPS returns mail to the sender for six months.

And the line on that page I'd tape to the wall: a change of address only changes the address with the Post Office. You still have to tell every agency and every company yourself. Forwarding is a net, not a notification. Who you tell, and in what order, is the next chapter.

One more thing on the mail, worth doing early because it works slowly. The Data & Marketing Association keeps a Deceased Do Not Contact List, and USPS links to it from that same page. Registration carries a processing fee — six dollars when I looked in 2026. Register the name there and USPS says advertising mail should decrease within three months of registering. Three months is a long time to wait for a small mercy, which is exactly why you do it in week one rather than in August when the catalogs have finally made you angry.

Reading that mail as a search for money your parent never mentioned is its own skill, and it has a chapter of its own later. For now you're only keeping it safe and keeping it in one pile.

Do not cancel the power

Last, the trap, because it catches careful people. The careful instinct in week one is to stop the outgoing money, and the most visible outgoing money is utilities.

Leave the electricity, the gas, the water and the internet connected. A house with no power has no sump pump, no furnace, no security system and no working smoke alarm after the batteries go. An unheated house in January costs more in one burst pipe than a winter of gas bills. The internet is often carrying the alarm panel, the camera at the back door and the thermostat you can check from your kitchen eighty miles away.

The subscriptions and the autopay on things nobody needs are a real problem, and Chapter 7 sorts those with a test you can apply to an envelope. Utilities on an empty house are not in that category. If money is the reason you're thinking about it, call the utility, say the account holder has died, ask whether the account can stay on and what they need from you, and write down who you spoke to.

The tool: the empty-house walkthrough

Do this once, with your phone, in one careful pass, before anybody tidies anything.

1. Thermostat: photograph it, set it, write the number and the date on the phone log.
2. Water: find the main shutoff, photograph it, decide on or off and write down which, and check under every sink and behind the washer for anything already dripping.
3. Power and gas: find the panel and the meter, photograph both, confirm nothing is scheduled to be shut off.
4. Every room, in order, one photograph from the doorway and one of any surface with things on it. Don't stage. Don't straighten.
5. Keys: list every person who might have one, with a phone number beside each name.
6. Firearms: locate, secure in place, photograph where they are, and leave them there until a lawyer and a licensed dealer tell you

what federal and state law require.

7. Medications: gather, get them out of the open, note anything controlled.
8. Mail: if you shared the address, start the one stack that everything joins from now on. If you didn't, call the local Post Office and ask what you may do while the estate waits for papers.
9. Perishables: refrigerator, freezer, the fruit bowl, the bag of dog food that mice will find.
10. The animal: who has it tonight, who has it next week, who is paying.
11. The outside: hose bibs, the spare key under the step, whether the garage door opener in the car still works from the road.

Then lock it, photograph the locked door with the date on it, and leave.

When this stops being your decision

One honest limit, and it belongs here rather than three chapters from now.

If that house has a mortgage on it, or a second name on the deed, or a reverse mortgage, or a tenant in it, you have moved past what a walkthrough and a thermostat can fix. Call a local estate lawyer this week and spend an hour of their time. I know what an hour costs. I also know what it costs to find out in month four that someone was supposed to be told something in month one, and that the person who was supposed to tell them was you.

The same goes if anyone asks you to sign something about that house — a listing, a deed, an insurance change — and you are not the appointed representative. Don't sign it. Ask the lawyer whether you have the authority to sign it at all. A signature on a house is not a draft.

Tomorrow the work moves to the telephone, and to the forty organizations that each think they're the only call you have to make today. There's an order to that, and it isn't alphabetical.

Lock the box first.

Chapter 5: Who Has to Be Told, and in What Order

By the Friday of that first week I had forty-one organizations written on the yellow legal pad, in three different pens, in no order whatsoever. Two banks. A credit union nobody had mentioned until Thursday. The pension. A seed company. The gas utility. A magazine about model trains that Gene had let run on autorenewal since the Clinton administration.

Forty-one calls is not a day's work. It is three weeks of hold music, and it was also the wrong way to look at the problem, because a list with no order in it is just a way of feeling behind forty-one separate times.

Dale looked at the pad over my shoulder and said, "Which of those is costing money right now?"

Four of them were. I did those four and let the rest sit until the following week, and nothing bad happened. That is most of what this chapter is.

Put the money ones first

Here is the sorting rule, and it is the only one you need.

Tell first the organizations where money is moving. Money going out of an account that nobody is watching. Money going in, to a person who is no longer there to receive it. Money that stops the moment somebody learns of the death, and money that keeps coming until somebody tells them.

Everything else waits. The gym waits. The magazine waits. The loyalty card at the grocery store waits forever, and if it never gets told, the sky stays up.

There is a second reason for the order, and it is about your own stamina. The calls get easier. The first one is the worst phone call you will make that week, and if you spend it on a subscription line in a different time zone, you have wasted it. Spend it where it counts.

Social Security, which you probably do not have to call

Start here, because it is the shortest item on the list and almost everyone assumes it is the longest.

The Social Security Administration's own page on what to do when someone dies says that funeral homes generally tell them when someone dies, so you do not typically need to report a death yourself. That sentence saves most families a phone call. It does not save you the two minutes it takes to confirm it happened.

So do this instead of calling: when you are next in contact with the funeral director, ask whether they reported the death to Social Security, and on what date. Write the answer and the date in the phone log. If they did, you are finished with this item.

If a funeral home is not involved, or nobody will confirm it was reported, then you call. The SSA's number is 1-800-772-1213, and the TTY number is 1-800-325-0778, available in most US time zones Monday through Friday, 8 a.m. to 7 p.m. Have four things in front of you before you dial: the name, the Social Security number, the date of birth and the date of death. That is what SSA's page says it wants. It is a short call when you have all four, and an awful one when you are hunting for the middle item while a recording thanks you for your patience.

If you are outside the United States, SSA directs you to a Federal Benefits Unit or to its International Call Center at +1-855-522-6936. If the person who died was a US citizen, SSA also says to report the death to the nearest US embassy or consulate.

What you may be able to claim from Social Security is a separate and much bigger subject, and it is Chapter 8. This call is only the telling.

The payment that lands in the account afterward

Now the mistake that costs families real money in the first month, and it is not a dramatic one. It looks like good news.

A benefit payment arrives after the death. Sometimes two. The account is open, the direct deposit is automatic, and the money sits there looking like it belongs to somebody.

Do not spend it. Do not move it to your own account “to keep it safe,” and do not let a sibling pay the funeral home out of it because the timing seems tidy.

I am not going to tell you whether that payment is owed back. The answer turns on the month it covers and on facts about your parent’s record that I do not have, and I could not find it stated plainly on SSA’s own site when I looked in 2026. So the instruction is narrower and safer than the one you want: call 1-800-772-1213, say what arrived and on what date, and ask whether any of it has to be returned and how. Ask for the answer in writing, or at minimum write down who told you, when, and the reference number they give you.

Then leave the money alone until you have that answer.

Leave it where it is.

Medicare, and the thing I will not make up

Medicare gets asked about constantly in that first week, and the honest answer is thinner than people want.

Social Security is generally the agency that learns of a death first, and the Medicare record follows from that record. That much is reasonable to say. What I could not confirm on Medicare's own pages when I checked in 2026 was the rest of it: exactly when coverage ends, whether a premium gets refunded, how a particular Medicare Advantage or Part D plan is closed out. Those answers vary by plan, and your cousin who went through this in another state in 2019 does not have them either.

So if there is an Advantage plan or a Part D drug plan, call 1-800-MEDICARE (1-800-633-4227) and ask what that specific plan needs from you and who has to provide it. Write the answer in the log with the date, because you will be asked by someone in your family who is certain they already know.

The employer, where four things sit in one drawer

If your parent was working, or had retired from somewhere with a pension, the employer or former employer is the single highest-yield phone call in this chapter. Ask separately whether there is a final paycheck, payable unused leave, group life coverage, or a pension or retirement-plan benefit. Do not assume any one exists.

Call the human resources or benefits department, say the employee has died, and ask each of the four as a separate question. Not "what happens now." People answer "what happens now" with the one thing in front of them on the screen.

Ask who the plan administrator is, ask for that administrator's direct number, and ask what form each item needs. Write all of it down.

This is also where the small forgotten policies surface, and the hunt for the ones nobody knew about is Chapter 9's job.

Notify is not the same as close

Banks, credit unions and brokerages come next, and there is one sentence here that will keep you out of trouble.

Say, "I am notifying you of a death." Then stop talking.

Do not say you are the executor unless a court has appointed you and you can prove it. Do not ask them to close anything. Do not ask them to move anything. Do not let a helpful person on the phone walk you into authorizing something, and do not sign a form that arrives in the mail three days later without reading what it says you are.

Who may close an account, move money, or write a check after a death depends on the account agreement, how the account is titled, any beneficiary designation, and the authority the institution requires. Do not move money or close anything based only on this book. If the institution says it needs court papers, the process for getting them is in *The Executor's Step-by-Step Guide*.

When you notify the institution, ask what recording the death changes, when the change takes effect, and which pending deposits or payments may be rejected. Have the appointed representative or estate lawyer confirm how necessary property expenses will continue.

Ask each institution the script below, and nothing beyond it. The certified-copy question in it is the one from Chapter 3's counting sheet, and this is exactly the week it earns its keep.

Insurers, and the policy on the credit card

Life, health, auto and homeowner's insurers all need telling. The house and car policies you have already dealt with if you worked through the walkthrough in Chapter 4, and the written answers you got there go in the same place as everything else.

Life insurance is different, because telling the insurer is the start of a claim rather than the end of an obligation, and the money usually belongs to a named beneficiary rather than to the estate. The claim itself is Chapter 9.

Then the one people miss. Look at the credit card statements for an accidental death rider, a small term policy sold through a bank, or a benefit attached to a union membership or a professional association. Check statements and membership materials for an accidental-death rider or separate policy. If you find one, call the named insurer and ask what its current claim process requires. The way you find them is by reading the mail and the statements, which is why the pile from Chapter 4 matters.

What can genuinely wait

Subscriptions. Streaming services. The gym. The warehouse club. The magazine about model trains. The frequent flyer account. The newspaper, unless it is piling up on the porch and telling the street that nobody lives there, in which case it is a security problem and goes to the top.

None of those is urgent, and all of them will take a cheerful customer service representative twenty minutes each. Which ones to stop and which to keep paying, and the test for an envelope you are not sure about, is Chapter 7.

The call that took eleven minutes, and the one that took three weeks

Two calls from that first week after Gene died, same morning, same legal pad.

The pension office took eleven minutes. I had his Social Security number, his dates, and an old pay stub with an employee number on it that I had found in a shoebox. The woman gave me her first name and a four-digit extension, told me which form would come and roughly when, and read me a reference number twice because I asked her to. I wrote all of it down. When the form came eight days later, it came exactly as described.

The bank took three weeks. I called their main number, spoke to someone perfectly pleasant, told them Gene had died, and hung up feeling like I had accomplished something. I did not get a name. I did not get a reference number. I did not write down the time.

Three weeks later, when it mattered, there was no record that I had called at all, and I had nothing to argue with. So I made the call again, properly this time, and lost the three weeks.

The difference between those two calls was not the institution. It was what I wrote down while I was talking.

The tool: four sentences and a number

Every one of these calls is the same call. Say these four things, in this order, and then do one thing at the end.

1. "I am calling to notify you of a death." The name, the date of death.
2. "I am the son or daughter. I am not telling you I have legal authority over this account." Say what you are, accurately. Nothing more.

3. “What do you need from me to record the death?” Let them talk. Write it down.
4. “Does that include a certified death certificate, and do you return it?”

Then, before you hang up: “Can I have your first name, a direct extension, and a reference number for this call?” Have them repeat the number back. Put it in the phone log with the time.

An unlogged call did not happen. That was Chapter 1’s rule, and this is the week it stops being advice and starts being the difference between eleven minutes and three weeks.

The master list, in four tiers

Copy this onto the pad and fill in the names from your own parent’s mail and statements.

This week, because money moves: Social Security, if the funeral home did not report it. The employer or former employer. Each pension or retirement plan. Each bank and credit union. Each brokerage. The life insurer. The health insurer, and the Advantage or Part D plan if there is one. The mortgage holder, if there is a mortgage. Home and auto insurers, if you have not already.

Next week: Credit card issuers. Any lender. The landlord, if there is one. Any professional association or union. The Department of Veterans Affairs, if your parent served, and Chapter 8 has the claim sheet for that.

Within the month: The state motor vehicle agency, by its own procedure, which you looked up in Chapter 4. Utilities, to change the account rather than to cancel it. Any government program paying into or out of the account.

Whenever you feel like it: everything else on your forty-one.

The point where you stop and call someone

Three things in this chapter mean you stop and get a lawyer on the phone before you make the next call, and I would rather say them plainly than have you find out in month three.

If a bank tells you they need Letters, or an order, or anything with the word “court” in it, that is a signal that the next step requires authority you may not have yet. If anyone asks you to sign a form that describes you as the executor, the administrator or the personal representative, and no court has appointed you, do not sign it. And if an insurer tells you the beneficiary on a policy is “the estate,” stop there, because where that money goes is a different question from who gets a check, and getting it wrong is expensive to undo.

A local estate lawyer can answer all three in a single paid hour. That is cheaper than any of them going wrong.

Next week the work goes quiet and turns to paper. Somewhere in that house there is a will, or there is not, and either way you are about to spend an afternoon opening drawers with somebody else in the room.

Get the reference number.

Chapter 6: Finding the Will and Everything Else

Week two started with Dale carrying a kitchen chair into Gene's old office so two of us could reach the top shelf of the closet at the same time.

"Why two of us," I said.

"Because if we find it, I want a witness who isn't you," he said.

"Not that I don't trust you. I don't trust either of us alone with a long week behind it."

He was right, and it is the first rule of this chapter before any list of places: do this with a second person in the room. Not because anyone expects a problem. Because grief plus a found document plus nobody else present is exactly the condition that turns an honest mistake into a fight six months later.

Where wills actually are

There is no national registry you call. A will lives in one of a short number of ordinary places, and you work through them in whatever order makes sense for your family.

The lawyer who drafted it, if anyone remembers a name or a firm. A home filing cabinet. A fireproof box, which in Gene and Helen's house turned out to be a gray metal strongbox under the bed with a key taped to the inside of Helen's jewelry box lid — not clever, just theirs. The person named as executor may already have a copy, or may know where the original sits. Some states let a person deposit a will with the county court for safekeeping while they're alive, so a call

to the county probate clerk asking whether one was filed costs you five minutes. And a bank safe deposit box.

The safe deposit box is the one that trips people up, because getting into it before an estate is formally opened depends on state law, and then on the bank's own policy stacked on top of that. Some banks will let a named co-renter in with nothing more than a key and identification. Others won't open a deceased person's box to anyone, co-renter included, until a court has appointed someone. There is no single answer, and guessing wastes a trip. Call the bank, ask exactly what it requires to open the box, and get a name and a reference number for that call, in writing if they'll give it to you. Write it in the phone log from Chapter 1.

We did not have a safe deposit box to deal with. Marlene did, for her husband's, and she told me later that the bank asked her for something the county probate clerk hadn't mentioned, and she lost a week finding that out the slow way. Ask both offices, not just one.

A deed or a tax return sitting in a desk drawer is simply there, waiting to be found by whoever opens the drawer. A safe deposit box has a lock, a key, and an institution with its own rules standing between you and the contents, and that institution did not know your family before this week and has no reason to make an exception for it. Treat the phone call to the bank as its own small errand, separate from the search through the house, and don't let it become the thing that holds up everything else.

What else you're looking for while you look

The will is the headline, but this is the week you also gather everything else that will matter for the next eleven, so look for it in the same pass instead of starting over later.

Deeds and titles to any real estate or vehicles. Tax returns — start with the most recent one you can find, and ask whoever prepares it

later which years actually matter for this estate, because that answer depends on facts you don't have yet. Insurance policies of every kind: life, health, long-term care, the small ones tucked in with homeowner's paperwork. Statements for every bank, brokerage, retirement and pension account you can find, even old ones. Military discharge papers, if your parent served — they may help with the VA burial claim in Chapter 8, but start the claim even if you do not have them. Marriage and divorce decrees. An address book, a Rolodex, a sticky note taped inside a drawer — anything with names and account numbers on it that a stranger would throw away.

Gene kept everything in one gray metal box and nothing anywhere else, which made this easy. Helen, three years later, kept things in four different places, two of which Ruth found by accident — a manila envelope behind the encyclopedias, and a shoebox in the hall closet that also held, as it turned out, the pay stub from Chapter 5's eleven-minute pension call. Your parents are probably somewhere between those two. Look slowly, with the second person, and don't throw anything away this week that you can't explain.

Touch it carefully

Once you find the will, do three things and avoid three others.

Do: read it once, calmly, before you decide anything about it. Do: note who is named executor, who are the beneficiaries, and who is named as an alternate if the first choice can't serve. Do: make a photocopy for your own working file and put the original somewhere it cannot be lost, spilled on, or carried off in someone's bag "just to look at it at home."

Do not sign it, initial it, staple anything to it, or write on it. Not even a date in the margin, not even in pencil. Do not let anyone take the original out of the house, including the person named executor, until you've asked a lawyer whether that's safe in your state. And do

not assume the will is final just because it's the only one you found. Look for a later date on a second document, a codicil, or language that says it revokes anything earlier.

Some states require the original will to be delivered to the probate court before anyone opens an estate, and the deadline can be short. Ask the probate clerk or an estate lawyer today what your state's rule requires; the filing process itself is in *The Executor's Step-by-Step Guide*. This chapter's job ends at finding it, reading it once, and keeping it safe.

What the will does not decide

A will may not control every asset; preserve any beneficiary or ownership record you find, and see *Estate Planning for Beginners* before anyone relies on it.

Reading it without panicking

The first time through, resist the urge to read every clause as a verdict on who was loved more. Wills are drafted in a lawyer's language, written years before anyone involved was thinking about this week, and they often say less than they seem to. A phrase that sounds cold on a Tuesday afternoon in week two was usually just standard drafting language in 2004.

What you actually need from this first reading is three names: the person given the job of carrying this out, the people set to inherit, and whoever stands behind the first choice if that person can't or won't serve. Write those three things on the same page as your document inventory. Everything else in the will — specific bequests, trust language, contingent clauses — can wait for the lawyer who will eventually help whoever is executor open the estate. That's a different conversation, and it belongs to a different week.

If something in the will surprises you, say so out loud to the person who was with you when you found it, and then set it aside rather than deciding what it means on your own at eleven at night. A surprising sentence read tired is rarely read accurately.

If there's no will at all

If you search everywhere in this chapter and there genuinely isn't one, your parent died "intestate," and every state has a default order for who inherits in that situation. It is not chaos, and you are not stuck — it means the next step is reading your own state's intestacy rules rather than a document your parent wrote. The probate clerk can point you to the current statute and local procedure, usually in one phone call. An estate lawyer can tell you how that statute applies to your family before anyone acts on it. It typically starts with a surviving spouse and children. The exact shares depend on how many of each there are, and whether any of the children came from a different relationship. Beyond that first ring, the rules diverge enough between states that naming one state's answer here would do more harm than good to a reader somewhere else.

Nothing else about your week two changes: you still gather the documents, still keep the originals safe, and still start the box and the notebook. The absence of a will does not mean the absence of a plan. It means the plan was written by your state legislature instead of your parent, and someone can read it to you.

What "not found" actually means

A tick beside "desk" should mean somebody looked through the desk, not that somebody remembers your father saying he kept papers there. On the inventory's reverse side, record the places actually checked and who checked them. Leave a separate entry for

places you could not access. A locked box is an unfinished search, not an empty one.

Keep a loose document with the envelope or covering letter it came in. The return address may identify the office that can explain what you found. Don't dismantle bundles to make a prettier pile before noting what was together.

Suppose the desk holds a photocopy marked "page 1 of 4," but the other pages are missing. Record exactly that, along with its date and the location where you found it. Look for the rest among the nearby papers and contact the office named on the copy. Do not fill the gap with a relative's recollection or label the copy "the will" as though the search were complete. An incomplete document needs assessment by the estate lawyer, not reconstruction at the kitchen table.

If someone says another folder went home with an aunt, record that lead and arrange a follow-up with her. You need to check that folder, not search the desk again.

The system that carries the next eleven weeks

Whatever you find, start the system here, this week, because you will be adding to it until day ninety.

One box for the original papers. One notebook or spreadsheet listing every document you found, with a column for found or not found and the date. A sibling calling from out of town can then ask "did we find the title to the Buick" and get an answer in one sentence, instead of sending someone through the house again.

Write down where each original now lives — the box, the drawer, whoever's glove compartment it rode home in — and don't throw anything away yet. What you can safely discard, and when, is a Chapter 12 question, not a week-two one.

The tool: the eight places to look, and a document inventory

Go through these in whatever order fits your family, with a second person present, and don't skip ahead to "we probably don't have one of those."

1. The lawyer who may have drafted it — a name on an old envelope, a bill, or a number saved in a phone counts as a lead.
2. Home filing cabinet or desk.
3. A fireproof box or strongbox, wherever it's kept.
4. The person named as executor, who may hold a copy or know where the original is.
5. The county probate clerk, by phone, asking whether a will was deposited for safekeeping.
6. A bank safe deposit box — call first and ask what the bank requires to open it.
7. A digital folder or cloud account, if your parent was that kind of organized.
8. Anywhere else papers lived: a nightstand, a closet shelf, a car's glove box, a relative who was asked to "hold onto this."

Then the document inventory, one line per item: deed, vehicle titles, tax returns (which years), life insurance policies, health and long-term care policies, bank and brokerage statements, pension and retirement paperwork, military discharge papers, marriage and divorce decrees, address book. Two columns next to each: found or not found, and the date you checked.

Helen's house, in 2019, had a folder already made — tabbed, dated, sitting in the second kitchen drawer where she always said it was. It did not make the grief smaller. It made the week shorter, which is a different thing, and the only thing a folder can do.

Next week the envelopes start arriving in earnest, and not all of them are yours to pay.

Chapter 7: Which Bills to Pay, Which to Stop, and What to Freeze

By the third week after Gene died in March 2016, the mail stopped being a trickle. If you're in weeks two to four now, this is the work on the kitchen table.

I had two envelopes from the same hospital on the kitchen table, six days apart, and they did not agree with each other. The first said Gene owed a little over four hundred dollars. The second, same account number, same dates of service, said eleven hundred and change. Neither one explained the other. Both had a due date printed in a box in the corner, and both were addressed to a man who had been dead for three weeks.

I sat there with my checkbook out. The invoice felt like something I'd left unfinished. Settling it felt like taking care of him one last time.

Dale came through, looked at the two amounts, and said, "Then it's their arithmetic, not yours. Make them do it."

I put the checkbook away.

Their estate, not your checking account

Their debts are generally paid from their estate, not your checking account.

The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's page "Does a person's debt go away when they die?", updated in September 2026, explains that debts are generally paid using the money or property the person left. If those assets cannot cover a debt and nobody else

was legally responsible, the CFPB says it may remain unpaid. Survivors, including spouses, generally do not owe it unless they shared legal responsibility or another exception applies.

An unpaid debt can be a lawful outcome. You do not have to repair a shortfall merely because you're the child answering the mail. Nor does this mean the estate can ignore a valid obligation. Those are different questions.

A balance on a statement establishes neither your personal responsibility nor permission to use your parent's account. Before payment, someone must establish both the obligation and the authority to pay it.

The exceptions, one at a time

I promised early on that I would walk through the exceptions rather than wave at them. "There are exceptions" is how a frightened person ends up writing a check. The CFPB lists five situations where you may be responsible for someone else's debt. Here they are, one at a time.

You co-signed a loan that still has debt outstanding. Your own agreement to repay matters; being the child who helped fill out the application is not the same thing.

You are a joint account holder on a credit card. The CFPB distinguishes this from being an authorized user. A card bearing your name does not, by itself, tell you which you are.

You are a surviving spouse and your state law requires spouses to pay that particular type of debt. Do not apply the adult child's answer to the surviving parent's bill without checking this exception.

You are the executor or administrator and your state law requires executors or administrators to pay an outstanding bill out of property that was jointly owned by the surviving and deceased spouses.

You are a surviving spouse in a community property state whose law requires jointly held property to be used for the deceased spouse's debts. The CFPB names Alaska if a special agreement was signed, Arizona, California, Idaho, Louisiana, Nevada, New Mexico, Texas, Washington and Wisconsin. Living in a named state is a reason to check, not proof that every bill is yours.

California supplies a verified example, not a national rule. Its Probate Code section 13550, checked on the official California Legislative Information site in 2026, addresses surviving-spouse liability with property limits and exceptions. For your state, ask the probate clerk for the official statutes and a local estate lawyer how they apply to your family. A clerk can locate the rule; a lawyer can interpret it for you.

The Federal Trade Commission's "Debts and Deceased Relatives", dated February 2023 and checked again in 2026, adds a warning for the person handling the estate. Someone legally responsible for resolving it may become personally responsible by failing to follow certain state probate laws. The CFPB's jointly owned-property exception is not permission to reach into your own account, and the FTC's warning is not a reason to pay every envelope.

If no exception applies, the CFPB says the debt belongs only to the estate. Establish that answer rather than borrowing it from the loudest relative.

Authorized user is not co-signer

Suppose your parent added you to a card to buy groceries. Your name is embossed on the plastic, and now someone says that makes the balance yours.

The CFPB's authorized-user answer, last modified in September 2024 and checked again in 2026, says that being an authorized user

generally does not obligate you to pay. A joint borrower and a permitted user have different responsibilities.

If a collector claims you co-signed and you believe you did not, the CFPB says you may request evidence, such as the signed contract. That same page says issuers generally report authorized-user status to credit bureaus, so the relevant part of your own report may help establish your role. It describes a free report once each year from each nationwide bureau through annualcreditreport.com or 1-877-322-8228.

Ask for the contract. In writing.

That means your report, not an attempt to obtain or freeze your parent's file. Chapter 10 owns deceased-consumer identity protection and collector conduct. Here you are answering a narrower question: did you agree to repay this debt?

The bill that came twice

Back to the two hospital envelopes.

I called billing with the Chapter 1 phone log open and asked why the amounts differed and which statement was current. The woman found an insurance adjustment, then a reversal, and a third statement already generated. I asked for the explanation and the corrected statement in writing.

The third statement, when it came, was for ninety-one dollars.

That was the amount the hospital was then asking for, not proof that I owed it personally or that it could be paid ahead of other claims. A corrected amount still needed the same authority check. My checkbook remained shut.

For a medical statement, ask what services it covers, whether insurance has finished processing, and whether it replaces an earlier statement. Have billing identify what it needs from an authorized person if it cannot discuss the account with you. Keep the old

statement beside the new one; crossing out the old balance does not explain what happened.

What to stop, and what to leave alone

Use the empty-house safeguards from Chapter 4 without doing that walkthrough again. This question sorts the recurring charges: does the payment still protect something or provide a service someone needs?

If not, mark it for cancellation by the person the provider authorizes. If it protects property, a claim, records or a survivor's coverage, get instructions before stopping it. An unfamiliar charge is not automatically useless.

A magazine nobody reads, a delivery box, or an unused membership is a candidate. A family streaming account may still serve the surviving parent. A storage subscription may hold the only copies of photographs. Do not cancel by the shape of the company name alone.

Tell the provider about the death using the Chapter 5 notification approach. Ask who may cancel, what documents it needs, when charges stop, and whether a remaining balance or contractual commitment exists. Get confirmation.

The CFPB's automatic-payments guidance, updated in August 2026, distinguishes cancelling a debit from cancelling the underlying contract or amount owed. That guidance describes your own account; it does not give an adult child authority over a deceased parent's account. Cancelling future service also does not establish that earlier charges are invalid.

Do not use your parent's login or sign as their representative to make the charges disappear. Ask the bank or provider for the procedure your actual role permits. Let the person with authority

coordinate autopay changes; shutting down an account wholesale can interrupt payments you meant to preserve.

For heat, insurance, a mortgage, rent or storage holding belongings, identify the next due date and any threatened interruption. Ask the appointed representative or estate lawyer who can authorize payment, which necessary payments should continue, and what account can lawfully fund them. The estate account, creditor-claim procedure and payment priorities belong to *The Executor's Step-by-Step Guide*.

Do not advance personal money because an envelope sounds urgent. If nobody is appointed and a lapse would endanger property, tell the lawyer that today. Ask the provider about an extension or temporary arrangement while authority is clarified; do not assume one exists. Keep necessary service in place through an authorized arrangement, not by promising personally to cover an unknown balance.

Open it, date it, put it down

Holding a bill means withholding payment while someone checks it. It does not mean ignoring its dates.

Read the mail you are entitled to handle as it arrives. Date your working copy or envelope, leaving original legal documents unmarked. Put any due date, hearing date or threatened service interruption on the list beside the bill. Route court papers and notices with response dates promptly to the representative and lawyer; a hold pile does not stop a clock.

Medical and credit card statements can wait for verification and the authorized payment decision, but not unseen in a drawer. Ask what is unresolved and who will check it. Record a follow-up date. If a bill arrives after you asked a question, attach it to the same record rather than starting a second, disconnected pile.

There is no national waiting period in this chapter. “Don’t pay yet” means verify and route, not leave every debt untouched until day ninety. When you hand a bill over, note who received it and when. If nobody accepts responsibility for checking it, you still have an open item.

Keep the receipts you think are too small to matter

If you’ve already spent your own money, start a separate expense record.

The county-office parking, locksmith and certified copies all get entries. So does a funeral deposit you personally paid. Keep personal purchases separate; a meal for relatives is not automatically an estate expense because you ate it while doing paperwork.

For each expense, record what it bought, when, who paid, and who authorized it, if anyone. Keep the receipt and evidence of payment together. Send the record promptly to the representative and ask what documentation and timing apply to a reimbursement request. Do not wait for the estate to finish before asking.

Reimbursement depends on the applicable law, the expense and what the estate can pay. I cannot promise it. Do not deduct your expenses from money you are holding or pay yourself back without confirmed authority. Recording a cost preserves the question; it does not decide it.

The tool: the four-pile sort

Clear the table. Take every envelope that has arrived since the death, plus everything you have already opened and shoved somewhere, and put each one into one of four piles.

Ask: who owes this, and what establishes that obligation? If you cannot answer, the bill is not ready for payment. Check response dates before sorting.

1. **Route for authorized payment.** The obligation has been checked. Give it to the authorized person for the payment decision, noting due dates and any unresolved issue. This is a handoff, not permission to pay it yourself or evidence that it takes priority.
2. **Hold, unpaid.** The amount, insurance processing or legal responsibility remains unclear. Add the person checking it and a follow-up date. Send time-sensitive notices onward even while the balance is unresolved.
3. **Challenge in writing.** Request an explanation of a disputed amount or obligation. If a collector claims you co-signed, request the evidence described above. Keep your copy and follow the notice's applicable response instructions with legal help where needed.
4. **Not an estate obligation.** Use this only when you have established that fact: an optional sales offer is one example. A renewal may instead reflect an existing contract. If the bill is yours personally, route it to your own records; this pile does not make it disappear.

Beside each item, note its pile, who has it and the next action date. Tomorrow's envelope can then join an existing question instead of becoming another mystery.

Where this stops being a paperwork problem

Call a local estate lawyer before committing money if a collector claims you're personally liable, a jointly owned house has a mortgage, or the known assets cannot cover the bills. Bring the

account agreement or loan papers if you have them. These are questions about liability, ownership and payment order, not how carefully you balance a checkbook.

The CFPB's September 2026 guidance says a collector may discuss estate debts with a surviving spouse or personal representative, but cannot falsely suggest personal liability when no exception applies. Being asked about a bill does not establish that you owe it. Have the lawyer identify the legal basis before you agree to pay, sign a repayment plan or supply your own card number.

If the estate appears short of money, do not select creditors by whose letter sounds angriest. Get advice before making payments. The FTC's probate-law warning is why doing the work carefully includes knowing when to stop.

Ask for a defined consultation and its fee in writing. For a disputed collection demand, ask whether consumer-law or debt-collection-defense help is also needed. The CFPB points readers to local lawyer referrals and legal aid for people who meet eligibility criteria; paying a private lawyer is not the only route to ask about.

Put the two statements together in the folder. Write who will check them and when. Leave the checkbook where it is.

Chapter 8: Government Benefits to Check

It's week three or four, and you're standing at the refrigerator with an appointment card in one hand and a pen that won't write in the other.

The funeral is behind you. Someone has taken the flowers away. The calendar still has your parent's haircut on it, but nothing about applying for a benefit. You have to put that there yourself.

Missing a claim need not mean someone was careless. A family can do every task it was given and still miss the task nobody mentioned.

Start with Chapter 5's notification contacts. This time you're asking whether a living person can claim a benefit, and what must happen next.

The small payment with its own clock

The Social Security Administration's "Lump-sum death payment" page, checked in October 2026, gives the amount as \$255, paid once. It is not an allowance payable to whichever adult child arranged the funeral.

SSA says a spouse might qualify. A spouse who wasn't living in the same home may still qualify if eligible for benefits on the deceased person's record. Separate addresses, including a care facility, are a reason to ask, not a reason to cross the claim off.

If there is no eligible spouse, certain children may qualify. SSA's 2026 guidance describes children age 17 or younger; children ages 18

to 19 attending school full time at the K-12 level; and children of any age whose disability developed at age 21 or younger. Being an adult child without that qualifying disability does not establish eligibility because you bought the casket or handled the paperwork.

According to that same SSA page in 2026, you must apply within two years of the death. The clock starts with the death, not the burial, not the date the certificate arrived, and not the day you found this chapter. Put the death date and the resulting deadline on your claim sheet.

For this payment, SSA's page currently offers an online application through the applicant's account. It also tells you to call 1-800-772-1213 (TTY 1-800-325-0778) and say you want to apply for the lump-sum death payment. Start at ssa.gov and follow its link; don't use your parent's login.

If you're helping the surviving parent, ask SSA how you may assist and what the claimant needs to do personally.

A monthly benefit is a separate question

Survivor benefits can provide monthly income based on the deceased person's Social Security work record. SSA's 2026 survivor guidance identifies possible claimants as spouses, former spouses, children and dependent parents. This is a benefit for an eligible survivor, not an estate asset available to divide among siblings.

Check both payments. Give each its own entry so that a yes about one cannot become a remembered yes about both.

Under SSA's eligibility page checked in 2026, a surviving spouse may qualify at age 60 or older, or at ages 50 to 59 with a qualifying disability. The general marriage-duration requirement is at least nine months before the death. SSA also describes restrictions involving remarriage before age 60, or before age 50 for someone with a disability.

Those are screening rules, not the whole decision. SSA names exceptions involving age and marriage duration, including some cases where the survivor cares for the deceased person's child. Tell SSA about that care and the child's circumstances rather than ruling the survivor out by age alone.

SSA's 2026 page says a former spouse whose marriage lasted at least ten years may qualify. Certain valid non-marital legal relationships may qualify too. Bring the marriage and divorce history into the conversation. It is not your job to decide whether an earlier marriage counts from a sentence somebody remembers.

For children, SSA's 2026 eligibility guidance gives the same basic age, school and disability categories described above, generally with an unmarried requirement. It also recognizes certain circumstances involving married children, adopted children, stepchildren, grandchildren and stepgrandchildren. An adult child's disability must have begun before their twenty-second birthday; needing help only later in adulthood does not establish that condition.

There is another person worth remembering: your parent's surviving parent. SSA's 2026 page identifies dependent parents age 62 or older who were financially supported by the child who died as possible claimants. If your father was helping pay his mother's rent, tell SSA and ask what support evidence is required.

Get an estimate before choosing a starting month

The size of a survivor payment depends on the claimant's circumstances. Your parent's last deposit is not a reliable calculation by itself.

SSA's "What you could get from Survivor benefits" page, checked in 2026, says spouse and ex-spouse payments can start at 71.5% of the deceased spouse's benefit. Its illustrations rise above 75% at age

61, above 80% at age 63, and above 90% at age 65. The page gives up to 100% at survivor full retirement age, which is between ages 66 and 67 depending on birth date.

Ask SSA for an estimate using the survivor's actual record, birth date, work and marital history. These percentages aren't your household's quote.

For children, SSA's 2026 amount page says the payment is generally 75% of the parent's benefit, subject to a family maximum that may reduce payments. Former spouses do not count toward that maximum. If several people may qualify, mention all of them and ask for the calculation rather than multiplying a percentage yourself.

SSA also says in 2026 that survivor and other Social Security benefits are not added together as two full payments. A person eligible for both chooses the payment that is best for them, and switching later may be possible. SSA gives the example of taking survivor benefits and later switching to a higher retirement benefit at age 70; confirm the sequence and available dates before filing.

The claiming-age comparisons and breakeven calculations belong to *Social Security, Claimed On Purpose* in the Plain Talk Retirement Series; here, get SSA's individualized estimates and establish the available claim before choosing its start date.

Call promptly to ask which filing and starting dates apply. Do not borrow the lump-sum payment's two-year deadline for the monthly benefit. Tell SSA if the survivor is still working; its amount page warns that earnings limits may temporarily reduce payments depending on age.

Make the application real

SSA's adult survivor application guidance, checked in 2026, directs you to call its national number and say "Survivor." It may help you file during that call or arrange an appointment. The online lump-

sum application is not an instruction to file every kind of survivor claim online.

That guidance also says people already receiving Social Security Family benefits generally have their benefit type and amount updated automatically. If that describes the surviving parent, ask SSA to confirm what is changing and whether anything remains to be filed. Already receiving one's own retirement payment is not the same description.

Use SSA's Form SSA-10 information page for a surviving spouse or former spouse, and its Form SSA-8 information page for the lump-sum claim. Both were checked in 2026. They name documents SSA may request, including proof of death and birth; the spouse's page also names the marriage certificate and, where relevant, a final divorce decree. Ask for the document list for the actual claimant rather than treating those pages as one universal packet.

SSA accepts photocopies of some records, such as wage statements, but requires originals of many others and says it returns them. Use the certificate tracking from Chapter 3 without redoing the count here. Confirm the submission route and the return arrangement before sending valuable originals.

Both SSA information pages tell applicants not to delay a claim because documents are missing; the agency will help obtain them. Call with the papers you have. Say which are missing. Record whether you have filed, merely booked an appointment, or still owe an action. A date written beside "called" is not proof of submission.

Ask about VA monthly survivor income

VA's "Survivors Pension and D.I.C." guidance, checked in October 2026, identifies surviving spouses, children and parents as possible claimants for Dependency and Indemnity Compensation (DIC). Its Survivors Pension page describes monthly payments for qualifying

surviving spouses and unmarried dependent children of wartime Veterans, subject to income and net worth limits. Have VA check the survivor's circumstances rather than treating a discharge paper as approval.

If your parent served, ask VA or a VA-accredited VSO representative whether the survivor should also apply for DIC or Survivors Pension, and whether to submit an intent to file now; these are separate from the burial allowance and may have different eligibility and payment start dates.

VA's "Your intent to file a VA claim" page, checked in October 2026, says an intent to file may protect a potential earlier start date if the claim is approved. Give DIC and Survivors Pension separate claim-sheet entries from burial benefits. Record any intent-to-file confirmation and ask VA for the deadline to complete that claim; an intent to file is not the completed application.

VA money begins with eligibility, not a receipt

A military discharge paper makes this worth checking. It does not, by itself, make every funeral bill eligible for reimbursement.

The Department of Veterans Affairs' "Veterans burial allowance and transportation benefits" page, updated October 1, 2026, describes separate routes. For a family-filed burial or transportation claim, ask VA who may claim the costs paid and which reimbursements affect eligibility. VA separately describes an automatic set payment for an eligible surviving spouse listed on the Veteran's profile; confirm what it covers before assuming no claim is needed for other expenses.

Its claimant categories include surviving spouses or qualifying legal-union partners, children, parents, estate representatives, other family members or friends, and representatives of funeral homes or cemeteries.

The Veteran's circumstances matter too. VA says the Veteran must not have received a dishonorable discharge and must meet a qualifying condition. Its page includes service-connected death, death during VA or VA-contracted care, certain VA-authorized travel, receipt of VA pension or compensation, and certain pending claims that would have established entitlement. It also describes cases where military retirement pay was received instead of VA benefits. Have VA check the actual history.

The same 2026 page excludes burial allowances for someone who died on active duty, while serving in Congress, or while serving a federal prison sentence. Ask about other applicable benefits separately.

Using Chapter 7's expense record, identify who paid and any organizational reimbursement. Ask VA which claimant and costs fit its rules before relatives submit overlapping claims.

Match the VA amount to the death date

VA's October 1, 2026 rate page lists a non-service-connected burial allowance of \$1,032 and a plot allowance of \$1,032 for eligible deaths on or after October 1, 2026. For deaths from October 1, 2025 through September 30, 2026, the listed amounts are \$1,002 each. For deaths from October 1, 2024 through September 30, 2025, they are \$978 each.

Ask VA to identify the applicable category and amount; neither allowance is promised to every claimant. Filing this October for an earlier death does not acquire the newest rate.

Check the date.

For service-connected deaths, VA's 2026 page lists \$2,000 for deaths on or after September 11, 2001, and \$1,500 for earlier deaths. Service connected means the death was due to an illness or injury

caused or made worse by active-duty service. Do not substitute “served in the military” for that finding.

The same VA page, as checked in 2026, lists a headstone or marker allowance of \$441 for deaths on or after October 1, 2025. Ask whether that allowance applies in your case. VA also has a separate government-headstone and marker program with its own eligibility and application; buying a stone does not establish a right to a refund. Check before committing that money.

The VA clock has exceptions

VA’s October 2026 guidance gives no filing time limit for burial or transportation allowances when the death was service connected. For a non-service-connected death, the burial claim generally must be filed within two years after burial. Notice the starting event: burial, not death.

VA’s 2026 page makes exceptions. There is no filing time limit for a non-service-connected death while under VA care at a VA health facility or a VA-contracted facility. There is also no time limit for the plot or interment allowance, or transportation allowance. If VA changed a dishonorable discharge status after death to another status, its page gives a two-year filing period from that change.

Have VA confirm any exception and keep evidence of the relevant burial date, care setting or discharge-status change. Write ‘no filing limit’ on the claim sheet only after VA confirms the exception applies to this claim.

According to VA’s 2026 guidance, death notification triggers the automatic set payment for a qualifying spouse recorded in the Veteran’s profile. That spouse need not apply for this payment. Confirm that the spouse is listed, what payment is being handled, and whether additional claimed costs need an application. Do not

assume the child who paid the bill will automatically receive money, or that an automatic payment answers every claim.

Put the VA papers together

You can apply online through va.gov or mail VA Form 21P-530EZ, Application for Burial Benefits. VA's October 2026 instructions give the mailing destination as Department of Veterans Affairs, Pension Intake Center, PO Box 5365, Janesville, WI 53547-5365. Confirm that address on the current form before mailing.

The VA page says you may need the death certificate including cause of death and an itemized transportation receipt if you paid to move the remains. It recommends a copy of the DD214 or other separation documents covering all service periods; it does not say a missing DD214 means you cannot begin. Follow its military-records request link and ask how to proceed while the record is being obtained.

For a service-connected claim, VA recommends supporting medical records and explains how to authorize their release if you lack access. Use those instructions or ask for help; don't claim authority to obtain records that you do not have.

Questions go to 1-800-827-1000 (TTY 711), listed by VA in 2026. If eligibility, discharge history or a denial is disputed, contact a VA-accredited representative before trying to interpret it alone. VA's September 2026 representative guidance says accredited Veterans Service Organization representatives help with benefit claims free of charge. Accredited attorneys and claims agents may charge fees; confirm any arrangement before appointing someone.

Keep national-cemetery eligibility separate from cash allowances. VA's national-cemetery guidance, checked in 2026, includes qualifying Veterans, spouses, minor children and some unmarried adult dependent children; surviving spouses may qualify even after

remarriage. Ask about eligibility and availability if burial arrangements remain open. VA also lists bereavement counseling for certain eligible families; Chapter 11 covers asking for that help.

The employer still owes you an answer

Return to the pension contact already identified in Chapter 5. This is the follow-up, not another search through the house. Known employer and pension plans belong on this sheet too; the lost-pension search belongs to Chapter 9.

Send a short written request asking four things: who may qualify for a survivor payment; what the plan's existing survivor election provides; which application and evidence it requires; and what filing date or other deadline applies. Ask the administrator to identify the governing plan document and confirm the answer in writing.

Plan terms and existing elections matter; do not assume a survivor can choose a different payout now. If the response addresses only the death notification, repeat the unanswered claim questions. If an entitlement or rejection is disputed, ask a lawyer who handles employee benefits to review it before a response deadline expires.

The tool: the benefits claim sheet

Use a separate page for each possible benefit and claimant. An empty deadline line remains an open question, not permission to wait.

1. **Benefit and claimant.** Name the payment, the agency or known plan, and the person who might qualify. Mark eligibility as unconfirmed until you have an answer.
2. **Application route.** Record the form or agency-directed process. Note who must sign and how you may help in your actual role.

3. **Clock.** Copy the agency's applicable rule, its starting event and that event's date. Add the calculated deadline, source page and date checked, or the confirmed no-time-limit exception.
4. **Evidence.** List required documents, which are missing, and how each will be obtained. Track originals through the Chapter 3 record.
5. **Submission.** Record when and how you filed. Keep the submitted copy, confirmation or mailing evidence. Record an appointment separately.
6. **Next action.** Name who will follow up and when. Record any evidence request, decision, response deadline or unresolved question.

For example, a VA burial claim uses the burial date. A plot claim gets its own deadline treatment. The SSA lump-sum claim uses the death date. Keep the source beside each entry so the clocks cannot swap places.

Take the appointment card off the refrigerator. Put it in the claimant's folder, and write what that appointment is for.

Chapter 9: The Policy Nobody Knew About

Seven weeks after my mother died, a letter came to the farmhouse from a company she had stopped working for in 1991.

It was addressed to Helen, the way those letters always are. No logo I recognized, a return address in Columbus, and I came close to putting it on the advertising pile. Inside was one page about a group life certificate, a number across the top, and a phone number under that.

She had never mentioned it. Not in 2019, sitting at the kitchen table going through the folder she had made for us. Not in the thirty years before. I don't believe she remembered it existed.

The amount was modest. But it was real, and it had been sitting somewhere since the first Bush administration.

The letter was found because someone was still opening the mail in week seven.

You are probably somewhere in weeks two to four. Start these searches now, because the answers take far longer to come back than the questions take to ask.

What this chapter is, and what it isn't

Chapter 6 was the paper search: the eight places to look, the document inventory, the boxes in the closet. Chapter 4 set up the mail so it keeps arriving somewhere a person will read it. This chapter is the other half, the part you cannot do by opening a drawer.

This chapter gives you six no-cost routes: official government searches, regulator-linked tools, and an association-run multi-state search that sends matches back to state programs. Nobody has to be paid to run them. I will name each one, say what it covers and what it does not, and then hand you a sheet to record the date and result of each search.

I am also going to tell you how to claim a policy you already know about, because that one has traps in it too.

The policy you do know about

Start with whatever turned up in the document inventory: a policy booklet, a premium notice, a benefits summary from an employer, a certificate like Helen's.

Find two things on it. The policy or certificate number, and the name of the insurance company.

Then find out whether that company still exists under that name. Insurers merge and get bought, and the name printed on a 1988 policy may belong to nobody now. Your state insurance department can help you work out who holds the book of business today. The National Association of Insurance Commissioners says every US state, the District of Columbia and the five US territories has a department of insurance whose job includes helping consumers; the NAIC indexes all of them on its consumer pages at naic.org.

When you reach the insurer, do not open with a claim. Open with a question: what does your company need, and from whom?

Ask who it treats as the claimant on this policy. Ask what form that person has to sign, and whether a different person can start the process. Ask what proof of death it accepts, whether that includes a certified copy, and whether it returns the copy afterward. That last pair is the same question from Chapter 3's certificate count, and the answer goes on the same sheet.

Life insurance money goes to whoever the beneficiary designation names. Chapter 6 covered why that designation sits outside the will. What matters this week is that you do not promise anyone a share of money that is not yours to divide, including yourself.

Three situations mean you stop and get advice before anybody signs anything: the named beneficiary died before your parent did, the designation is blank or illegible, or two people both believe the policy is theirs. Ask the insurer in writing who it treats as the claimant and on what basis, then take that written answer to an estate lawyer. A signed release is hard to walk back.

If the insurer stops answering

Insurers are not all the same, and some of them get slow once the file leaves the first desk.

Give the company a fair chance first. The NAIC's guidance on filing a complaint says to try to resolve the problem with the insurer before going over its head. Keep a record of every call and letter with dates and times, which is what the phone log has been doing since Chapter 1.

If that fails, your state department of insurance investigates complaints at no charge. The NAIC lists unfair claim delays, denials, failure to honor a policy and a lack of timely communication among the things a department can look at. Its filing advice is practical: gather the policy number and your documentation, complete the department's complaint form, write a factual account that sticks to what happened and when, use the policy's own language where you can, and say what outcome you want. The NAIC also says an insurer cannot discriminate against you later for having complained.

A complaint is a record of the issue for the state department. Keep the complaint number, every attachment and the insurer's written response.

The free hunt for policies nobody mentioned

Now the harder case: you think there might be a policy, and you have no paper at all.

The NAIC runs the Life Insurance Policy Locator. Its own consumer page describes it as a free tool that helps beneficiaries search for unclaimed life insurance policies. Start at naic.org, follow the link from the consumer section, and read what it asks for before you begin.

It is free. Say that part twice to the relative who forwarded you an advertisement.

I cannot tell you how long it takes to hear back, or which companies it reaches, because the NAIC does not publish either of those as a promise. Run it, write the date you ran it on your sheet, and keep going with the rest of the list.

Money a state is already holding

Unclaimed property is where a forgotten savings account, an uncashed refund check or a utility deposit from 1996 ends up after the company holding it gives up on finding the owner. It does not disappear. It goes to a state program.

The National Association of Unclaimed Property Administrators, a network of the National Association of State Treasurers, keeps an index of every state's official program at unclaimed.org. NAUPA also runs MissingMoney.com, a free site that searches participating states at once and links you to the official state program when there is a match.

NAUPA states the position plainly: there is no fee to search for and claim unclaimed property through your state's official program.

Search every state your parent ever lived or worked in. The state where they died is one of several. Search a maiden name. Search the

name with a middle initial and without one, and search the obvious misspelling that a payroll clerk might have typed in 1978.

NAUPA's page on searching beyond your state also points to federal sources families rarely think of. Unclaimed insured deposits from closed banks go through the Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation. Accounts from liquidated credit unions go through the National Credit Union Administration. Matured savings bonds sit with Treasury, and mortgage insurance refunds with the Department of Housing and Urban Development.

Whether a particular state will release property to you, and what it requires first, is set by that state's program. Read its claim instructions before you fill anything in.

A pension that outlived the company

If your parent worked somewhere with a pension and that employer is gone, the money may not be.

The Pension Benefit Guaranty Corporation keeps a plan search at pbgc.gov covering trustee plans and plans paying PBGC premiums. PBGC cautions that a plan's payment of premiums does not by itself prove PBGC coverage or that a benefit is due. Treat a result as a lead, then ask the listed contact what plan applies and whether any benefit is payable. Each entry gives the sponsor's name, its employer identification number, the plan number and a contact telephone number. Use the sponsor, plan number and contact number as leads. Ask the contact whether it administers the plan, who may ask about a deceased participant, and what authority it requires.

PBGC also keeps a separate database of unclaimed retirement benefits: money that went unpaid to people whose plans ended. PBGC's page says the database is updated quarterly and names the date of the most recent update, which was August 5, 2026 when I looked. The search asks for a last name and the last four digits of a

Social Security number, and PBGC prints a privacy notice explaining what it does with that. Read the notice, and ask PBGC how a survivor or a representative should proceed rather than guessing. PBGC publishes its own pages on eligibility, on what to do before contacting it, and on the documents needed to claim a benefit.

A known employer plan is different work. That one belongs on the claim sheet from Chapter 8, where you are chasing an administrator who already has your parent's file.

If your parent served

The Department of Veterans Affairs keeps an unclaimed funds search of its own at insurance.va.gov, and it has nothing to do with the burial money in Chapter 8.

VA says these are insurance funds owed to certain current or former policyholders, or to their beneficiaries, where VA has been unable to locate the person to make payment. The page lists the older programs involved, with names like National Service Life Insurance and Veterans Special Life Insurance. VA states on that same page that the search does not include Servicemembers' Group Life Insurance or Veterans' Group Life Insurance policies from 1965 to the present, and tells holders of those policies not to use it.

It takes a last name. If your father or mother served, run it.

The people who want a percentage

Somewhere around month two, a letter may arrive from a company that has found money in your parent's name and would like to recover it for you.

Run every free search in this chapter first.

NAUPA is direct about this. Third-party finders and locators do exist, they often charge a percentage of what is recovered, and in

most cases they are operating legally. NAUPA also says that many states require finders to register or hold a licence, that some states cap the fee, and that all of the same information is available at no charge through the state's own program or MissingMoney.com. Its advice before you sign anything is to contact your state's unclaimed property office and check the finder.

That is my advice too, extended one step. Before you agree to anything with anyone who contacted you first, verify the asset directly with the agency, insurer or plan that supposedly holds it. Then get the fee, the scope and the authorization terms in writing, and read what you are authorizing them to sign on your behalf.

Pressure does not prove fraud, but it is a reason to pause. Verify the asset directly with the holder and read the proposed fee, scope and authorization before signing.

The day something actually turns up

You find a policy. A state says it is holding eleven hundred dollars. The letter from 1991 lands on your kitchen table.

Do nothing with it yet.

Write it down: what it is, who says it exists, the reference number, the date you learned about it, and what the holder says it requires. Then work out whose money it is before a dollar moves. A payment to a named beneficiary and an asset belonging to the estate are two different things with two different sets of rules, and the person who has to sort that out is whoever has authority. What the estate then does with an asset is *The Executor's Step-by-Step Guide*, not this book.

Tell the appointed representative about anything you find, promptly, even if you are sure it is a beneficiary payment. A found asset can change the answer to Chapter 7's question about whether the estate can cover what it owes.

And do not deposit a check made out to your dead parent into your own account. Ask the bank what the person with authority has to do instead.

The tool: the found-money sweep

One page. Six searches. Beside each one, write what it needs before you start, the date you ran it, and what came back.

1. **The policy you have.** Insurer's current name and the policy or certificate number. Call and ask what it needs and from whom. Record the claimant, the form, the proof of death and whether documents come back.
2. **The NAIC Life Insurance Policy Locator.** Free, from naic.org's consumer section. Read its requirements first. Write the submission date.
3. **Your state's official unclaimed property program.** Found through unclaimed.org. Free. Run it for your own state first because that is the one you can telephone.
4. **MissingMoney.com.** Free, run by NAUPA, several states at once. Search every state your parent lived or worked in, plus the maiden name and the likely misspelling.
5. **PBGC.** The plan search at pbgc.gov for a plan whose sponsor you can name, and the unclaimed retirement benefits database for a benefit that went unpaid. Read PBGC's privacy notice and ask how a survivor should proceed.
6. **VA unclaimed funds**, at insurance.va.gov, if your parent served. Not the burial allowance, and not SGLI or VGLI.

Write a future review date on the sheet if new mail, employer records or a state-program instruction gives you a reason to search again.

Keep reading mail while forwarding is active and while claims, account questions, and the searches on this sheet remain open. Put a review date beside each open item.

Chapter 10: Protecting a Dead Person From Fraud

By month two, you may be sitting beside your parent's phone, watching it ring and wondering whether answering it will create another job.

Marlene got a call three days after her husband's funeral. The caller knew his full name and date of birth. He wanted her to fetch his Medicare card so he could "finish the file."

She left the card in the drawer.

She brought a question across the road afterward: how did he have the birthday?

Knowing a birthday does not prove someone works for Medicare or a bank. A public death notice can supply details. So can other records. You need not discover where the caller found them before refusing to supply more.

You want to prevent identity misuse without losing the photographs or messages worth keeping. Closing everything at once can work against that.

The notice does not need the whole biography

If the obituary is still being written, leave out the street address, full birth date and mother's maiden name. You can describe a life without supplying every detail someone might use to impersonate that person. A town, a year and the people who mattered can do the work.

Tell whoever submits the notice which details you want withheld. Check the version that will go online, not just the paragraph your cousin sent you. Avoid publishing photographs of certificates, identity cards or paperwork with account numbers visible.

During a funeral or memorial service, ask someone you trust to stay at the otherwise empty house. Keep the arrangement private. Chapter 4's empty-house safeguards still apply.

If sensitive details are already online, ask the publisher what it can remove. Editing the page may not erase copies elsewhere. Don't blame yourself for a notice written while you were barely sleeping. Start with what remains under your control.

Ask the bureaus about a deceased consumer

The Federal Trade Commission's "What To Know About Identity Theft," dated September 2024 and checked again in October 2026, explains credit freezes and fraud alerts for people protecting their own reports. It does not establish your authority to put either on your dead parent's file.

Use the FTC's [IdentityTheft.gov](https://www.ftc.gov/identitytheft) credit-bureau contact page to reach Equifax, Experian and TransUnion. As checked in October 2026, it lists Equifax at 1-800-685-1111; Experian at 1-888-397-3742 (1-888-EXPERIAN); and TransUnion at 1-888-909-8872. These are contact points, not a deceased-consumer application procedure.

Contact each bureau. State that the consumer has died and describe your actual role. Ask for its current deceased-consumer instructions and required proof of authority in writing. Follow that bureau's directions, using the secure submission route it identifies; do not send identity papers to an address supplied by an unsolicited caller.

Do not request a freeze or alert in your parent's name unless the bureau confirms in writing that you may and explains what it

requires. Do not describe yourself as executor if that is not your role. Being the child who found the statement does not settle the authority question.

Ask how the authorized person can later review the file, report an unfamiliar account and confirm that the bureau processed the death notice. Request a reference number and a follow-up date. Put the answer in Chapter 1's phone log rather than keeping it in your head.

Do not borrow a living consumer's checklist and change the name. Get the applicable instructions from each company.

An unfamiliar bill needs checking, not guessing

A new account notice, an unexplained withdrawal or a bill for something your parent never bought needs prompt attention. The FTC's identity-theft guidance names unfamiliar bills and transactions as warning signs. They are reasons to investigate, not proof that every late envelope is fraudulent.

Keep the envelope and the notice. Record the account identifier, the transaction date and what seems wrong. Pass the evidence promptly to the person with authority over the affected account. Verify the business through contact details obtained independently, such as its official website or an earlier genuine statement. Ask its fraud team how to report a deceased customer's suspected identity theft and what evidence it needs.

For identity theft that appears to have occurred, go to IdentityTheft.gov. The FTC's guidance checked in 2026 says the site provides a free recovery plan and prepared letters and forms. Spanish reporting is available at RobodeIdentidad.gov; the FTC lists 1-877-438-4338 for telephone help, including other languages.

State the death and your role. If the site's choices don't fit, call for guidance rather than describing yourself as the victim. Reporting

suspected theft does not give you account access or let you sign for the estate.

If money is moving without authorization, contact the institution's fraud staff now. Ask what protective action it can take and what the authorized representative must do next. Don't wait for the checklist below.

A collector's call has boundaries

Chapter 7 dealt with whether a debt is yours. A genuine debt can still be collected improperly; an unpleasant call does not establish that the bill is fake.

In its debt-collection law guidance rechecked in 2026, the CFPB describes the Fair Debt Collection Practices Act as covering personal, family and household debts. It generally does not cover the original creditor collecting its own debt or business debts. The protections below concern collectors covered by that law; ask your state attorney general about additional state protections.

In its February 2023 guidance "Debts and Deceased Relatives," rechecked in 2026, the FTC distinguishes debt discussions from requests to locate the estate representative. Permitted discussion roles include the surviving spouse, a deceased minor's parent, legal guardian, lawyer, authorized estate representative and a mortgage servicer's confirmed successor in interest. Being an adult child alone is not one of those roles.

A collector may contact relatives without that authority to obtain the representative's contact information, but the FTC says it cannot discuss the debt's details with them. The guidance describes limited circumstances allowing a further contact. It is not an invitation to repeatedly argue the balance with whichever child answers the phone.

If you are only helping locate the representative, say that. Do not negotiate or promise payment. If you are the representative, get the written information before addressing the demand, and use the four-pile sort from Chapter 7 for the resulting papers.

The CFPB's deceased-debt guidance, updated September 2026, says collectors must provide validation information during the first communication or within five days. A validation notice identifies the collector and creditor, the account if applicable, the current amount and its itemization, and how to respond. Its validation page, rechecked in 2026, also requires the dispute period's end date.

According to that CFPB validation page in 2026, the written-dispute period is 30 days. A timely written dispute requires the collector to pause collection of the disputed amount until it adequately responds. Give the notice promptly to the authorized representative to confirm the deadline and act. A telephone objection or filing the bill away does not have the same effect. This is not the estate's probate claim deadline.

The CFPB's harassment guidance, also checked in 2026, says the Fair Debt Collection Practices Act prohibits harassment, oppression and abuse. It names repeated communications intended to harass, abusive language, false arrest threats and misrepresentations about the amount owed. Preserve messages and written demands; note what was said during calls without assuming you may record a conversation under your state's law.

Complaints can go to consumerfinance.gov/complaint or your state attorney general's consumer-protection office. State collection laws can differ; ask that office about yours. California's attorney general, for example, publishes collection guidance at oag.ca.gov but says the office cannot provide individual legal assistance. If there are threats, disputed signing authority or court papers, call a consumer or estate lawyer promptly to establish the response deadline. A complaint does not answer a lawsuit.

The probate claim process belongs to *The Executor's Step-by-Step Guide*; this chapter does not set the estate's payment order or court timetable.

The Medicare card stays out of the conversation

Medicare.gov's fraud-and-abuse page, checked in October 2026, tells readers to protect their Medicare and Social Security numbers. It says Medicare will not call to sell something or visit your home. It also describes limited situations in which Medicare or someone representing it may return a call and request information. "Medicare never calls" is therefore the wrong test.

End an unverified call and contact the agency yourself through its published number.

Report suspected Medicare fraud at 1-800-MEDICARE (1-800-633-4227), or use the HHS Office of Inspector General's reporting page at oig.hhs.gov/fraud/report-fraud/. Those routes are listed on Medicare.gov in 2026. Say that the beneficiary has died and ask how you should supply the information.

Check statements you may lawfully review against the service dates, not just the mailing date. A statement arriving after the death may concern earlier care. Ask the provider to explain an unfamiliar charge; report suspected misuse if the explanation does not resolve it. Do not create a Medicare account posing as your parent to investigate.

A password is not permission

Your parent's phone may be in your hand. Their password may be on paper. Neither fact answers whether you are entitled to read their messages or act through an account.

Do not sign in as your parent or reset credentials to make yourself the account holder. Use the provider's deceased-user process or access expressly authorized for your role.

Find each provider's help page from its own website. Ask separately about reporting the death, preserving data, obtaining permitted content, memorializing the account and deleting it. Memorializing means retaining a form of the profile after death; the actual features and conditions belong to that provider. It is not the same request as access to private messages.

The provider may require proof of death and legal authority. Apple Support's August 2026 deceased-account guidance describes verified legal documentation, with requirements varying by country or region. Google's deceased-user page, checked in 2026, describes reviewed requests, not password release. Neither establishes a procedure for other providers.

Ask the estate lawyer which law applies to a disputed access request where your parent lived. Owning a device and receiving its stored communications can involve different questions. If the account belonged to an employer, contact that employer rather than treating it as a family account.

Hold deletion or memorialization until needed content is preserved or the provider confirms that the change will not prevent its release.

Leave it intact.

Keep the number until you have a reason to release it

The FTC's two-factor authentication guidance, checked in 2026, explains that verification can involve a text, email, authenticator app or security key. The phone may therefore matter, but it is not the key

to every account. Keeping it active does not grant permission to use a code sent to your parent.

Before cancelling the line, ask the carrier how to handle a deceased customer's service, who may authorize changes, and what will happen to voicemail. Ask the account providers what contact route the authorized person should use. Keep necessary service only through an authorized payment arrangement, following Chapter 7's recurring-charge test.

Set the next review date around outstanding preservation requests, not an arbitrary number of months. If the line was cancelled, ask the carrier what remains recoverable. Don't buy a stranger's promise to retrieve everything.

Keep the handset and any separate memory cards secure. Do not factory-reset it, trade it in or let someone erase it while content questions are outstanding. Do not try to bypass its lock. If you have shared a family plan, ask about the other users' service before approving a change to the account.

Save the photograph, not every private conversation

Name what matters before asking for access: the porch photograph, the voicemail your parent left you, the recipe sent years ago. A specific request is easier to think through than "save everything."

Start with copies lawfully yours: messages sent to you or photographs in your own account. For material held only in your parent's account, request authorized preservation or release. A photograph visible on a screen may not have a separate copy on that device.

When you receive content through permitted access, keep the original files and make a separate backup in storage you control.

Open the saved photograph or play the audio to check that it works. A link to an account scheduled for deletion is not a saved file.

Private messages may concern other people too. Keep recovered material private while the authorized person decides what may be shared. Don't put identity papers or passwords in the family group chat.

The tool: the fraud-prevention week

These seven actions are a work plan, not a waiting period. Move suspected theft or a legal response date ahead of the schedule. Beside each action, write "done on," the person responsible and the next unanswered question.

1. **Review public details.** Ask the obituary publisher about removing sensitive information. Use the actual notice URL on this line. If a service is still ahead, arrange the house sitter privately.
2. **Contact the bureaus.** Start with [IdentityTheft.gov/CreditBureauContacts](https://www.identitytheft.gov/CreditBureauContacts). Obtain each company's deceased-consumer directions, including authority and later review; record a separate result for each.
3. **Route suspicious activity.** Identify unfamiliar account activity and contact the verified institution promptly. Use [IdentityTheft.gov](https://www.identitytheft.gov) for suspected identity theft, accurately stating the death and your role. Keep confirmations with the evidence.
4. **Check collection demands.** Use the CFPB's validation and harassment guidance at [consumerfinance.gov](https://www.consumerfinance.gov). Send time-sensitive papers to the authorized representative; complaints and court responses are separate tasks.
5. **Check medical misuse.** Review lawfully available service records and report suspected Medicare fraud through

Medicare.gov's fraud page. Note the questioned service date and report reference, not your parent's full identifiers on this sheet.

6. **Ask before changing digital service.** Find the carrier's and providers' official deceased-user help pages. Record each URL, permitted requester, preservation question and consequence of closure. Confirm the payment arrangement for anything still needed.
7. **Preserve permitted content.** Save what is already yours and request other material through authorized channels. Check each received file and its backup before an approved deletion, cancellation or device handoff.

Write the next unresolved action beside the phone. Then leave the handset where the person responsible can find it, not in the box going to the donation center.

Chapter 11: Your Brother, Your Sister, and a House Full of Things

On the second weekend in June 2016, Kevin stood in our parents' bedroom with his hand on a chest of drawers neither of us wanted.

Dad had died in March. Mom was still living there. We weren't emptying her house; we were trying to decide what to do with his things without making her home disappear around her.

Kevin thought the chest should come to me. I thought he wanted it. He wanted something settled before his flight back to Tucson. I wanted to go home.

The top drawer wouldn't shut properly. Neither of us had room for it.

I asked whether he actually wanted it.

He took his hand off the top. No. He thought I did.

It stayed where it was. We hadn't even established whose furniture we were discussing.

If you're in months two and three, you may recognize that room. A cupboard is open, someone has brought packing tape, and a visit has turned into a deadline without anyone agreeing to one.

The return flight is not the deadline

The early weeks gave you appointments. A person told you where to be, what to bring, or which form was missing. Now someone says the house ought to be cleared by Saturday, and Saturday means the day they hired a van.

Ask what actually requires the date. A confirmed tenancy ending, a necessary repair or a lawful sale may need action. Someone's wish to be finished is different. Record the real requirement and ask the person with authority what must happen by then. You do not have to divide belongings merely because a van is outside.

Permission to enter a house is not permission to allocate its contents. A surviving parent may own the furniture and need the kitchen equipment. Roommates may have belongings there too. Ask before treating everything as something to inherit.

Chapter 4's freeze rule bought time. This is a discussion method for items the authorized person confirms may be considered, not permission to move them.

Ownership, a will's instructions and state law come before any family picking system. California Courts' property-after-death guide, checked in 2026, describes a legal transfer process even when there is a will. Ask your own county probate clerk where to find the official guidance for your state. If ownership or authority is disputed, take the papers to a local estate lawyer before anything leaves.

The legal work of estate administration and distributions belongs to *The Executor's Step-by-Step Guide*; this chapter stays with the conversation around the belongings.

The work nobody else saw

The child who did the caregiving can hear "we all need an equal say" as though the night calls never happened. The child who lived far away can hear "you weren't here" as though distance cancelled the relationship.

Do not make a sideboard carry the argument about who visited. If the caregiving needs to be acknowledged, acknowledge it in words. If there is a claim for money spent, route it through the expense record from Chapter 7. Do not silently compensate yourself by taking the

sideboard or decide that a sibling's absence forfeits whatever they may legally receive.

The nearby child has another problem: everybody's plan requires their hands. "We should get photographs of the dishes" means you should drive there after work, take the photographs, send them and answer the questions about the plates behind the plates.

Name the job.

A distant sibling can organize the pictures, telephone a service provider with permission, or circulate the proposed method. They need an assignment they have accepted, not a general promise to help.

You can say, "I can meet the repair person on Thursday. I cannot spend Sunday packing. Who is taking Sunday?" If nobody agrees, Sunday is unassigned. It is not secretly yours.

A house-clearance deadline may require paid help. Have the authorized person approve the scope, payer and cost before booking it. Don't assume that being the one who hired the cleaner makes the estate obliged to repay you.

The chipped bowl has two values

An object can be cheap to replace and impossible to replace in your memory.

The chipped mixing bowl is where you remember your mother stirring cake batter. Your sister remembers being told not to touch it. Neither memory comes with a receipt.

Ask what someone wants the object for before arguing about its price. They may want a permitted copy of the recipe or a photograph rather than the bowl. Establish the request.

For a value tally, agree what the figures mean. A dealer's estimate, an insurance figure and your guess are not interchangeable. If value

is uncertain, ask the representative whether a qualified appraisal is needed. Don't call an item worthless because nobody recognizes it.

And don't give every story a cash price. You can record that two people want the same object without deciding whose memory costs more.

No choosing while standing in the doorway

Make the preference list away from the house. Use photographs already lawfully taken, with enough detail to tell the brass lamp from the lamp with the bent shade. Give each item an identifier. "The lamp" is not enough when there are lamps in every bedroom.

Send the same version to everyone entitled to participate, rather than just the siblings who answer quickly. Have the authorized person confirm the group; beneficiaries may include other people.

Let people mark wanted, not wanted or undecided. Set a reasonable reply date everyone has received, with a way to ask for more time. No reply means no reply. It does not mean consent or a lost legal entitlement.

My preferred sentence is this: "I'm not deciding that today. Write it on the list."

It records a request without approving it, including the promise someone says your father made in a conversation nobody else heard. Record that as a claim, not "belongs to" beside their name.

If a specific gift is already directed by valid papers, that is a question for the authorized person, not a prize in your drawing. If someone disputes those papers, stop the picking discussion about that item. A friendly vote cannot resolve the legal question.

Choose a method before anybody chooses an object. Rotating picks can spread first-choice opportunities; drawing lots can decide an agreed order. A value tally may fit a group that wants to compare

estimated amounts. None is a legal formula, and none overrides the will, ownership or other people's rights.

I prefer a written method to "we'll be fair." You can point to the agreement. Otherwise everybody points at themselves.

When the executor is also the daughter

If you are the representative, identify your role. "As your sister, I'd like the quilt. As the representative, I haven't confirmed that it can be released."

Keep your preference on the shared page. Don't exclude it because you are doing the work or hide it because wanting something feels improper. It belongs in the permitted discussion.

Separate practical updates from private information. You can say that an ownership question is outstanding without forwarding identity documents, confidential advice or account numbers to the family chat. Ask your lawyer what information you may share when you're unsure.

If you propose paying for packing or storage, record the quoted amount, what it covers and who would pay. Keep an expense out of the preference tally. Spending money to pack an object does not make that object yours.

You cannot promise that everyone will like the answer. You can tell them what question remains, who is answering it and when you expect the next update. If the date slips, say why rather than letting silence carry the message.

When your sibling has the appointment

If someone else is the representative, send a focused written request. Ask for the current list of belongings being considered, the proposed

method and the next update date. Identify the item that matters to you and any ownership information you actually have.

“I’d like to be included when you discuss the sewing machine. Please tell me whether it’s available to consider, and when you’ll send the preference list” is clearer than a chain of messages about why nobody tells you anything.

Propose an update rhythm that fits the work. A weekly email can be useful during an active clearing period; a later date may make more sense while an answer is outstanding. These are suggested arrangements, not a legal reporting schedule. Ask for urgent changes promptly rather than waiting for the agreed email.

Legal reporting rights depend on your role and state law. This list cannot replace required estate records. If requests go unanswered or you suspect unauthorized removals, preserve your messages and ask an estate lawyer about options and response dates. Don’t take something yourself to settle it.

If the disagreement is about preferences rather than rights, you can ask whether a neutral mediator would help. Confirm the fee and what the mediation would cover. Do not use a meeting to pressure someone into giving up a legal claim they don’t understand.

No method requires you to sit in a room where you are threatened. Leave an unsafe meeting. Use written communication or professional help instead of treating physical attendance as proof that you care about the family.

The tool: the dividing method

This is a proposed agreement about preferences, not a transfer document. Put it on one dated page, attached to the shared item list. Everything material goes in writing; an oral change does not quietly replace the page.

1. **Confirm the boundary.** The authorized person identifies which items can enter the discussion, who may participate and what questions remain. Exclude another owner's property, legally directed gifts and disputed items until cleared. Mark every preference as provisional; nothing on this page authorizes removal.
2. **Collect requests.** Circulate identified photographs and one common list. Each participant marks their preferences by an agreed date. Record missing replies and arrange follow-up rather than treating silence as assent. Keep disputed promises visible as unresolved claims.
3. **Agree on the choosing rule.** Record the method, order, treatment of ties and how a pass works before picks begin. For rotating picks, write how the first chooser changes between rounds. Put anything requiring valuation or legal advice on hold instead of improvising an exception.
4. **Record and check the result.** Write each proposed recipient beside the item identifier, including holds and things nobody wants. Circulate the result for written confirmation. The authorized person checks that any eventual release is lawful and permitted; record an approved handoff separately. A disagreement stops that item, not a rush to the car.

For a worked example, suppose two participants are confirmed as eligible to express preferences about a small set of permitted household items. Both want a mixing bowl and neither wants a bedside cabinet. One also wants a framed print; the other wants a mantel clock. All requests are provisional.

They draw lots for the first pick, agreeing to reverse the starting order next round. The first chooser provisionally selects the bowl. The other selects the clock, then starts the next round and passes.

The first chooser selects the print. Nobody wants the cabinet; it stays unchosen, not assigned to make the count look even.

Before a handoff, the representative finds that the bowl may belong to the surviving parent. That selection goes on hold, and the parent is asked. The drawing did not answer the ownership question. A packed box does not answer it either.

The example assumes no conflicting gift, value question or other restriction. It cannot calculate inheritance shares or establish what the estate can release.

Keep the page. Date corrections, obtain participants' written agreement and get the authorized person's check where necessary.

The cereal aisle is not on the schedule

You can get through a morning of papers and then stand in front of a box of cereal unable to remember what you came to buy. Something on the shelf looks like the breakfast your father ate. Or nothing particular happened, and you cannot keep shopping.

It can happen early or much later. There is no week when it is supposed to arrive.

The National Cancer Institute's patient summary on grief, updated in February 2025 and checked again in 2026, describes sudden pangs prompted by reminders or no apparent cause. It also says people's grief responses differ. That is more useful than a timetable telling you where you ought to be by now.

Don't use your ability to complete a form as evidence that you aren't grieving, or your brother's quieter face as evidence that he isn't. You can ask for help without comparing how visibly each of you hurts.

Make the help small enough to accept. Ask someone to bring supper, accompany you to an appointment or take over a permitted

task with a specific end. If you cannot bear another question about how you feel, say that you'd like company without questions tonight.

Help that does not start with another packing box

For older adults and their families, the Administration for Community Living's Eldercare Locator connects people to local services at eldercare.acl.gov. Its contact number, checked in 2026, is 1-800-677-1116. The CFPB's September 2026 guidance specifically names it for older Americans and caregivers, including free legal aid for eligible older adults. Ask which local service fits the living person who needs help. It is not a promise of free representation for every adult child or every estate dispute.

Chapter 8 mentioned VA bereavement counseling. The Department of Veterans Affairs' September 2026 page identifies possible surviving spouse, child or parent eligibility. It covers service members dying while serving the country and Reservists or National Guard members dying on active duty. It also names Veterans receiving Vet Center services at death and Veterans or service members who died by suicide.

This is narrower than "my parent was a Veteran." Ask the nearest Vet Center about your circumstances. VA lists free outreach, counseling and referrals, with in-person and telehealth options; its 2026 page gives 1-877-927-8387 (TTY 711) for contact. You do not have to solve the eligibility question before making the call.

Call your doctor or a mental health professional promptly if you cannot cope, sleep or eat adequately, or distress is keeping you from basic daily tasks. Especially if this has been continuing for weeks, don't dismiss it as something you must endure until the estate is finished. Tell the clinician what has changed and how long it has been happening so they can assess what help you need.

The National Institute of Mental Health's guidance checked in 2026 recommends professional help when symptoms interfere with daily life or you are struggling to cope. Numbness alone is not a diagnosis. You can still ask for help.

For thoughts of suicide or urges to harm yourself, get immediate help. NIMH's crisis guidance checked in 2026 directs people to call or text 988, the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, and to call 911 in a life-threatening emergency. Tell someone you trust what is happening. The belongings can wait.

When nobody needs a form tonight

As the work thins, an evening can feel worse because nothing tells you what to do with it. You had a reason to sit at the table for weeks. Tonight the next letter has not arrived.

You don't have to start clearing another cupboard to earn the right to sit down. You can leave tomorrow's job on the page and telephone someone without making the call about the house.

Send the preference list before the next visit. Put an agreed stopping time in the message. When that time comes, close the cupboard and go home without settling the last object.

Chapter 12: Day 90, and the Help Worth Paying For

Near day ninety after my mother died in 2019, Sam slid my notebook back across the desk and asked which question I wanted answered first.

I had booked a ninety-minute consultation with the Chillicothe estate lawyer. The folder's elastic strap left a dent in the paper. My first question was "Am I finished?"

He asked what was still outstanding. I turned pages. There was a tax-return question, an unanswered letter, and a note that said "check this" without saying what this was.

I left with jobs assigned and a question for the tax preparer. I paid for a list of decisions I no longer had to guess at.

If you are approaching day ninety, put your notebook on the table. Some entries may be finished. Others may have started only when a new envelope arrived. The final income tax return can reach into the following April. That is work to schedule, not evidence that the first three months went wrong.

If funds are insufficient or personal responsibility is uncertain, get tax and legal advice before committing money; do not ignore the filing or payment date while that question is answered.

For final-return, refund, transcript, and estate-tax work, see *The Executor's Step-by-Step Guide*.

Pay for the question you cannot safely answer

Choose someone who prepares deceased taxpayers' final returns. An enrolled agent or CPA with relevant experience may be appropriate, as may another qualified preparer whose work fits the return. If there is a trust, rental business or other business interest, say that when making the appointment. Ask whether the person handles that kind of work or will refer it elsewhere.

The IRS's "Choosing a tax professional" page, updated in August 2026, describes differing credentials and levels of expertise and links its preparer directory. A preparer tax identification number permits paid preparation; it does not prove experience with your parent's situation. Check claimed credentials with the issuing body and ask about the actual task.

An estate attorney answers a different set of questions. A disputed will, uncertain ownership of jointly held property, insufficient assets to meet debts, or real estate in another state warrants legal assessment. A blended family may need help establishing rights even when everyone is being civil. Tell the lawyer the facts that complicate the answer, rather than asking for "some paperwork help."

Use Chapter 11's state-check route for local guidance. Ask a lawyer licensed in the relevant state whether another state's counsel is needed.

A financial adviser is for a decision about managing money that belongs to you, not a substitute for sorting your parent's returns or establishing ownership. Broader investment choices can wait until the money, taxes and immediate needs are understood. A deadline affecting an inherited account cannot wait merely because you are postponing investment shopping; flag it to the preparer and account custodian promptly.

My rule is to choose the adviser yourself, not appoint the stranger who contacted you after the death. That is a precaution, not a finding that every unsolicited offer is fraudulent. The SEC's Investor.gov site,

checked in 2026, links a “Check Out Your Investment Professional” resource and warns about pressure to act now. Begin there to check the person’s claimed registration, and ask how they are paid before discussing a product.

A small engagement needs a clear edge

“Review these papers and identify deadlines needing action” defines a task. “Take care of everything” leaves the scope uncertain.

You can request a flat fee for a limited consultation or return, but the professional may use another billing method. Get the scope, rate, likely additional charges and payer in writing before agreeing. Ask what changes would require another approval. Do not assume the estate will reimburse a consultation you hire personally.

At the first meeting, identify the client. The lawyer may represent the estate’s representative rather than every beneficiary. Ask what information can be shared and whether someone with a separate interest needs independent advice. Paying part of a bill does not resolve those questions.

Bring the focused question page and the Chapter 6 inventory, plus the papers the office requests. Ask which original documents are needed and keep a record of anything the office retains. Use the secure delivery method it identifies for tax records and identity information.

Ask what sorting or authorized document requests you can do yourself. Sorting by tax year is different from deciding how an amount should be taxed. Leave that judgment to the preparer.

Before you leave, establish the next deliverable and who is responsible for it. A consultation may give advice without including the filing of any form. A prepared return may still await review and the proper signature. Write those distinctions beside the appointment entry.

When the right office cannot take you

“Our next appointment is in May” doesn’t answer the date on the notice beside your phone, so read that date to the intake person before accepting a place on the calendar that may be too late. Ask whether someone there can assess the time-sensitive question sooner or suggest an appropriate referral. If the office cannot help in time, keep looking through the verified professional and referral routes above. An appointment isn’t protection.

Suppose you have a letter you don’t understand and quotes from two offices. One offers a short meeting next week. The other offers a larger package next month. Compare them against what the letter requires, not just the bottom-line price. Ask the first office whether its meeting can address that letter and the second whether its proposed work includes an assessment soon enough to help you act before the date you read over the phone. The cheaper quote may leave that job undone.

You needn’t tell your parent’s whole history to every receptionist. Give the relevant state, your actual role, the kind of problem and the date on the paper; if the office needs to see the notice before deciding whether it can help, ask how to send it safely.

Check later availability. The IRS’s Topic 254, updated in September 2026, recommends considering whether a preparer will remain available to answer questions after filing. At intake, ask how later questions are handled and whether that work costs extra. Don’t assume “we prepared it” includes help with every subsequent letter.

If the professional cannot continue, ask who, if anyone, has agreed to take over. Arrange access to the work already done and verify the replacement’s role. A referral name is a lead; it isn’t confirmation that the new person has your papers or knows about the approaching date.

Make the appointment usable

Tell the office what would let you participate. You may need a telephone appointment because you live out of state, a quieter room because hearing is difficult, or time to read a written explanation. Ask what it can arrange and what that would cost. Don't nod through advice you cannot hear because everyone else seems ready to finish.

If another person comes with you, establish whether they are there to take notes or participate in the decisions, and ask the professional what permission is needed before the companion sits down with the open file. They can write while you listen. That doesn't mean speaking for you or receiving every private paper afterward.

Try saying it back. "I understand you're reviewing the letter, but you haven't agreed to send a response." Let the professional correct your understanding. If the answer depends on information you haven't supplied, ask which information. Keep that uncertainty visible instead of leaving with a confident instruction nobody actually gave.

Pressure is not a qualification

An actual response deadline deserves prompt action. A sales pitch demanding a signature tonight deserves verification. Ask for the notice or official source establishing the date, and contact the known professional independently.

The IRS's September 2026 Topic 254 warns against preparers whose fees depend on a percentage of the refund or who propose putting the refund into their own accounts. It tells you never to sign a blank form.

Use Chapter 9's finder check for recovery offers. Decline an engagement if fees remain unexplained in writing or you are pressured to grant authority you don't understand.

If the budget is tight, the IRS's Topic 254 names VITA and Tax Counseling for the Elderly as possible free preparation routes for qualifying taxpayers. Ask the local site whether it can handle this final individual return and your signing circumstances. The IRS says an out-of-scope return is referred for paid help; eligibility does not mean every estate-related task is covered.

The tool: the day-90 review

Make one dated review page with four fields for each open item. They can run across a sheet or underneath each other in your notebook. This is an audit of unanswered work, not a demand to finish it all today.

1. **Open item.** Name the unresolved question precisely: a missing tax-year statement, an unconfirmed claim submission, or a disputed invoice. Refer to the existing file instead of recopying sensitive account details.
2. **Who owes the answer.** Name the person or office expected to respond and the person responsible for following up. If a professional has not accepted the work, record that; an appointment request does not assign the job.
3. **Deadline and source.** Enter the full date, applicable tax year or claim, official source or notice, and date checked. Bring over the SSA lump-sum date and the applicable VA claim dates or confirmed exceptions from Chapter 8's sheet, including any intent-to-file completion date. A blank needs prompt verification.
4. **Next action with a date.** Write the call, document request or authorized filing needed, who will do it, and when. Distinguish a follow-up reminder from the legal deadline. Attach submission proof when the action is completed.

For example, “final return” is too broad. “Preparer to confirm whether a missing interest statement includes amounts paid after death” gives the next call a purpose. The deadline field holds the confirmed filing and payment dates, or says they still need immediate verification. The next-action field names who will request the statement and the day they will contact the office.

Bring other unresolved entries forward by reference. Check for new agency requests, not just the questions already on your page.

The box is not ready for the shredder

Chapter 6 promised a records check here. Do not destroy papers because the ninety days are over.

The IRS’s “How long should I keep records?” page, reviewed in June 2026, ties tax-supporting records to the applicable return’s limitation period. It treats property records separately, linking their retention to the year of disposal, and warns that other purposes may require longer retention. That is why I will not give your whole box one discard date.

Add a records section to the review sheet. For each record type, write “keep until,” the date or condition given, who supplied it and where the records will be stored. Ask the representative, tax preparer and estate lawyer which papers support returns, property basis, claims and court filings. Basis is the tax value used when calculating a gain or loss; preserve the supporting papers without calculating it from this chapter.

Put filed returns and their supporting records on a line. Give property and valuation papers their own line, separate from payment receipts. Include claim correspondence and legal originals rather than assuming the tax preparer’s answer covers everything. Record the latest applicable instruction. If the answer depends on a future

event, write the condition and a review date, not an invented expiration date.

Ask what must remain on paper; scanning does not settle that. Use Chapter 10's preservation check for authorized digital records and identify their custodian.

Keep pending records.

If professional answers conflict, or a claim is unresolved, leave the record in place while you obtain clarification. An approaching retention date prompts another check; it does not override a later need.

Pick the earliest unanswered deadline on the review page. Contact the office responsible for that answer, with the relevant paper beside the phone. When the call is recorded, put the folder somewhere you can find it tomorrow. The table can be used for supper tonight.

The Green Folder in the Second Drawer

A year after our own papers were signed, in May 2025, Jess sat at my kitchen table with a stack of school papers and the green folder beside her elbow.

She had come down from Columbus for the afternoon. The papers had red marks on them. Mine had tabs. We pushed both piles away from the patch of sunlight coming through the window because she wanted to put her tea there.

“Is this still where you keep it?” she asked.

The second drawer, under the silverware. Yes.

She looked toward the drawer, then back at me. I realized she was checking the distance between an answer and a place she could actually find. I had been treating the folder as something I maintained. She was treating it as something she might someday have to reach for without asking me.

I stopped explaining how much work it had been.

What those ninety days changed

By then I had buried both parents and spent enough afternoons sorting their papers to know how much affection can coexist with irritation. I could miss my mother while wishing she had put a name on an envelope. Neither feeling cancelled the other. That irritation is most of why the folder in my own second drawer exists now; building it is its own job, and *Estate Planning for Beginners* is where that job gets done, not here.

What changed in me wasn't a filing system. It was smaller habits, worn in by ninety days of practice. I write the call down now — who I spoke to, what they said, the date — instead of trusting I'll remember it by supper. I ask an institution whether it needs a certified copy and whether it returns it before I order a single one, rather than guessing a number and hoping it's enough. I check whose debt a bill actually is before I reach for a checkbook; most of the time, if it isn't mine and it isn't the estate's, it stays unpaid. And I open the mail. All of it, the day it arrives, even the envelopes I'd rather leave on the counter.

Sitting across from my daughter, I wanted another afternoon exactly like that one, and then another. I couldn't give her a reason to need those habits less. I could only tell her where one drawer was, and let that be enough for one Tuesday.

She didn't promise me that she would handle everything. I didn't ask her to.

Everything includes jobs you haven't named and days the other person has already promised to their own family. I could tell Jess where my papers lived without trying to claim those days in advance.

You don't have to keep being the emergency person

For the first weeks after a death, being reachable can become the shape of your whole day. You bring the phone into the bathroom. You leave a meal unfinished when it rings. You start answering an ordinary question as if a stranger at a counter is waiting for the correct words.

If that has become your habit, notice it before deciding it is your permanent job.

Someone may still need an answer about your parent's affairs. The open work on Chapter 12's review page remains real. A reply date does not disappear because you want a quiet evening. But being

responsible for a named task is different from remaining available to everyone, for anything, indefinitely.

I had learned that feeling frightened of a bill didn't tell me whose bill it was. A fresh envelope could still contain news I hadn't known to look for. Neither was a reason to surrender my entire evening before I had read the page.

Put one name and one reply date beside the open item, so you know who's answering it and when. Then tell a relative, plainly, that tonight's call cannot be another discussion about the house. If you need someone to take over an authorized task, ask them and confirm that they have accepted it. Don't substitute silence for a handoff.

I dislike advice that tells a tired person to find a grand new purpose. Some days I wanted to finish an errand without someone needing a document.

You may want an evening in which your parent's name is not followed by an account number. You may also want to say that name over supper. Someone willing to listen can hear about your father without helping with a form.

And you needn't make all the conversation tender. An argument, a bad habit, a visit you disliked — those belong to the memory too. This book has asked you to handle tasks carefully; it has not asked you to revise your parent into someone easier to miss.

If the relationship was painful, completing the practical work does not oblige you to announce forgiveness. Leave that question unanswered if it isn't answered yet. A signed receipt or a returned key cannot settle it for you.

For me, grief sometimes occupied a whole evening and sometimes appeared in a sentence I had nearly spoken. I would start to tell my mother something and remember that there was no call to make. On another day I could go from breakfast to bedtime without that interruption, then feel unsettled when I noticed. I didn't learn anything useful from the contrast. I missed her. I went to bed.

If distress is making daily life hard or is worsening, tell your doctor or a mental health professional what is happening so they can assess the help you need. The National Institute of Mental Health's help guidance, checked in 2026, names difficulty completing daily tasks as a reason for professional help. Chapter 11 has the detailed help routes; you need not wait until the remaining papers are dealt with to use them.

Something with your own name on it

When you're ready to put this book down, the next task may still concern your parent. Or it may concern you.

If the work now needs court authority or continued estate administration, follow that question into *The Executor's Step-by-Step Guide* with your own court's current instructions and legal advice beside it.

If you are looking at your own unmarked envelopes and wondering what another person would make of them, *Estate Planning for Beginners* takes up that separate work.

Read what fits your question, rather than borrowing a new worry from a book title. The unresolved date on your review page deserves attention; an optional reading plan does not deserve the same urgency.

Choose something, too, that has nothing to do with papers. Keep the dental appointment you postponed. Ask a friend to meet you for lunch without bringing the folder. Walk down a street that isn't on the way to your parent's house. These aren't treatments or proof of recovery. They are things you are allowed to want.

If today was the funeral, this afternoon at my table may seem a long way off. You do not have to imagine yourself there. Stay with the work that belongs to today. There is no duty to turn what has happened into a useful experience before you have slept.

If it has been months, you don't owe anyone a performance of being finished. An unanswered letter and a reasonably good day can exist together.

At the table, Jess lifted her school papers off the folder. She had marked a page while I was talking. The tea was cold. I had not told her everything I might want to tell her about my parents, or about being the person who answered the phone afterward.

I could tell her another time. I could also ask about her day.

Before supper, I asked her to put the folder away herself. I wanted to see whether my description matched the kitchen she could see.

She opened the drawer beneath the spoons and found the space. The folder went in without moving anything else. She shut the drawer with her hand, and I turned back to the stove.